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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT ISSUES ORDINANCE ON FINANCIAL ACCOUNTABILITY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

President Ramchandra Paudel issued the Fiscal Procedures and Financial Accountability Act (First Amendment) Ordinance 2024 on Thursday.

Issuing a press statement on Thursday, Shailaja Regmi Bhattarai, Spokesperson for the Office of the President, informed that President Paudel issued the Ordinance in accordance with Article 114 (1) of the Constitution of Nepal on the recommendation of the Council of Ministers.

DPM KHADKA TO PERFORM PM'S DAILY DUTIES



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka shall be performing the Prime Minister's daily administrative tasks in the latter's absence.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' left for Uganda on Thursday to participate in the 19th summit of the Non-Aligned Movement. During his time away, DPM Khadka will be handling his duties, informed a statement released by the President's Office.

As per the statement, Khadka was given the responsibility by President Ramchandra Paudel on the recommendation of PM Prachanda.

Today's Supplement Highlight

Barking Deer: Shy creature of the forest

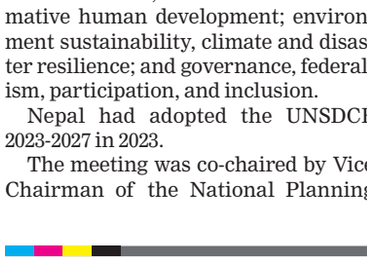




PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' waves at the Tribhuvan International Airport before departing for Uganda to take part in the 19th summit of the Non-Aligned Movement on Thursday.

Minister Sharma's one year in office

Policy reform, good governance in priority

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the Ministry has initiated legal, policy and structural reforms within a year of assuming office as the minister.

In a press conference held at the Ministry on Thursday on the occasion of the completion of one year in office as Communication Minister, Minister Sharma said that the Ministry strongly believes that Nepal's communication and information technology sector can be restructured through legal and policy reforms.

Minister Sharma, who is also the government spokesperson said that the government-led by Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has also studied and investigated some issues against corruption as zero tolerance policy to implement the agenda of good governance, social justice and prosperity.

Minister Sharma took charge of the Ministry of Communication on January 17, 2023. The Ministry of Communication has the scope to work in areas related to mass communication, information technology, postal service, printing, telecommunication and film industry.

Minister Sharma said that the government is moving forward in the areas of good governance, social justice and prosperity, implementation of the constitution and strengthening of federalism, reform and revival of the economy, investment promotion, job creation, improvement and simplification of public service delivery, citizen-friendly administration, and corruption control.



Please scan QR code for video.

Minister Sharma said that the government has been moving ahead with the main goal of strengthening the federal democratic republic and bringing about transformation in the living standards of the people through it by safeguarding and implementing the constitution.

Minister Sharma said that although communication and information technology is a new and dynamic field, since the laws that guide it are decades old, the work of its restructuring has been started through legal, policy and structural reforms under the Ministry, Minister Sharma said.

Within a year, some policies and regulations have been passed and implemented, while other necessary laws, policies and regulations are in the process of renewal and amendment.

Minister Sharma said that within the period, the government has discouraged the tendency of hoarding the frequency licenses, non-payment of revenue to the state by issuing new frequency policy-2080 by scrapping the old one and was set to implement technology neutrality policy from July 16, 2024.

Social media regulation in place

Minister Sharma said that within the year, the Ministry has issued the Social Media Management Guidelines-2080, as there were no such rules and regulations to regulate haphazard use of social media. Similarly, the National Cyber Security Policy-2080 has been

» SEE PAGE 6

PM leaves for Uganda to attend NAM meet

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has left for Uganda, leading a Nepali delegation to attend the 19th summit of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM). He left here early in the morning on Thursday via Qatar Airlines.

The NAM summit is being held in Kampala, the capital city of Uganda, on January 19-20. The PM-led delegation comprises his daughter Ganga Dahal, Foreign Minister Narayan Prakash Saud, Foreign Secretary Sewa Lamsal and senior officials of the Nepal government.

PM Prachanda is scheduled to address the summit that is being held under the theme, 'deepening global cooperation for shared global affluence' on Friday.

He is attending the special ceremony to be organised by the Ugandan President in honour of the visiting delegation chiefs the same day.

In course of the summit, the PM will be holding bilateral meetings with his counterparts from the attending countries. Foreign Minister NP Saud had already left for Uganda for the ministerial meeting on the run-up to the main event of the NAM summit.

It is said the 19th summit is to dwell on the ministerial report, review the implementation status of the 18th NAM Summit and pass a Kampala declaration.

Nepal is a founding member of NAM and has been attending the NAM summit actively since its establishment. Non-alignment is one of the fundamental foreign principles of Nepal. NAM was established in 1961.

PM Prachanda will return home on January 21.

Cabinet approves green hydrogen production and use policy

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

After the government endorsed the Green Hydrogen Policy-2080 through the cabinet meeting held on Wednesday, green hydrogen can be produced and used in Nepal.

The meeting of the Council of Ministers passed the policy to allow the production and use of green hydrogen.

The policy-making process of using 'green hydrogen', which is being developed as a modern green energy in the world, has been started since November 2021 to bring it into use in Nepal.

» CABINET DECISIONS

When Pampha Bhusal was the Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, she directed the Water and Energy Commission (WEC) to formulate the necessary policy for green hydrogen production and its use.

After that, WEC Secretary Mani Ram Gelal formed a coordination committee under the leadership of Shishir Koirala, a joint secretary of the Commission.

Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Energy Chiranjeevi Chataut, Deputy Director General of Power Development Department Jeebachha Mandal, Deputy Executive Director of Alternative Energy Promotion Centre Navraj Dhakal, Professor of Tribhuvan University Institute of Engineering Dr. Bholanath Sharma Ghimire and Deputy Professor of Kathmandu University Biraj Singh Thapa were the members of the committee.

Biraj Singh Thapa, head of Nepal Hydrogen Initiatives under Kathmandu University, said that after the government passed the policy, the production and use of green hydrogen could officially be done in Nepal.

Since no policy had been made yet, Kathmandu University was producing hydrogen as a pilot project by building a laboratory. Some time ago, the university created a hydrogen vehicle and even a refuelling station.

In India, the use of hydrogen energy has already started as a cooking fuel as well as operating buses. Thapa said that even in Nepal, hydrogen energy can be used for cooking and driving.

Thapa said that the use of hydrogen would help reduce the import of petroleum products and reduce the trade deficit. He also said that necessary arrangements would be made if coal or diesel-based industries wanted to be powered by hydrogen and the government would prepare regulations for this.

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting allowed to own 585 ropanis of land for establishing Chaujahari New City under the Gharigaun Land Integration Project and allowed to own 677 ropanis of land area for implementing Khurkot Land Integration Project.

The government also approved the visit of Minister for Forest and Environment Dr. Birendra Prasad Mahato to Nairobi, Kenya, to take part in the United Nations Environment Assembly (UNEA-6) to be held from February 24 to March 1, 2024.

Nepal, UN reach agreement on sustainable dev priorities

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

The Government of Nepal and the United Nations in Nepal have agreed on the priorities for the coming year for the four outcomes under the UN Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework (UNSDCF) 2023-2027.

The agreement was made at the first annual meeting of the Joint Steering Committee of the Nepal UN Sustainable Development Cooperation Framework 2023-2027 jointly organised by the government and the UN in Nepal in Lalitpur on Thursday.

The four outcome areas are sustainable, resilient, and inclusive economic transformation; inclusive and transformative human development; environment sustainability, climate and disaster resilience; and governance, federalism, participation, and inclusion.

Nepal had adopted the UNSDCF 2023-2027 in 2023.

The meeting was co-chaired by Vice Chairman of the National Planning Commission, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, and UN Resident Coordinator in Nepal Hanaa Singer Hamdy.

Speaking at the meeting, the Vice Chairman stated that Nepal looks forward to graduating from the LDC status in 2026 and implementing the 16th Plan.

"In this context, Nepal seeks scalable, transformative, and impactful support of the UN to create more employment opportunities, boost productivity, and productive capacity, promote sustainable use of natural resources, fortify the data management system for evidence-based policymaking, and enhance access to quality education and health facilities," he said.

"The Joint Steering Committee provides strategic oversight of the development and implementation of the Cooperation Framework, to ensure strong co-ownership and alignment with national priorities as outlined in the upcoming 16th National Plan and guided by the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development," read a joint statement issued by the NPC and UN in Nepal.

Likewise, Hamdy stated that

» SEE PAGE 6

KMC's cyber security training project receives overwhelming response

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

The Cyber Security Training project announced by the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) has drawn the tremendous attention of youth and witnessed the fill-out of 1032 forms in 24 hours till Thursday evening while 8,855 people have shown interest in the skill development programme in the past three days.

According to the KMC, this is an overwhelming response to the programme which also exhibited that there was a huge gap in Information and Communication Technology and cyber security.

The metropolis has designed 43 courses on digital technology and cyber security in seven categories such as basics of cyber security, information privacy, programming and networking, cloud networking and data analysis.

The training designed as an open online course has different modules



and courses ranging from 16.5 hours for beginners to 100 hours, said Nisarg H. Acharya, Vice-President of EC-Council, a company providing technical and knowledge support to the KMC for the training.

The EC-Council collaborates with its Nepal-based partner, Gap Technologies, to manage the contents as well as the technical side of the training as planned by the KMC.

KMC and its partners said that the training aimed at creating a workforce that would fit the demands of global companies. The trainings are designed for Information Technology literate to university degree holders. The trainees can get certificates after fulfilling the assessment and certification criteria of the courses.

The training will be organised online and will be free of cost. The trainees are required to attend the designated class hours, complete the readings of materials and appear in the assessment exams.

"Our cursory assessment found that many employees working at the government and private sector offices and teachers urgently needed training on cyber security. Although the higher officials are well-trained, the lower-rank employees can be vulnerable points for hackers and other criminals, and cyber security of the company could be compromised," said Shailendra Jha, an Expert Member of the City Planning Council (CPC) of the KMC.

The skill development project aims at producing or developing competing and skilled human resources for companies from various sectors both public and private. Jha said that the project was an initiative to protect people's privacy and protect them as well as companies from cyber-related risks.

The KMC and partners are responding to the need for employed workforce

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: YAGA RAJ AANDEMBE\RSS

Himalayan region women are selling herbs in the Gauradaha market of Jhapa.

Japan signs agreement to purchase 400 Tomahawk missiles

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 18

Japan signed a deal with the United States on Thursday to purchase up to 400 Tomahawk cruise missiles as part of its ongoing military buildup in response to increased regional threats.

Prime Minister Fumio Kishida's government has pledged to double its annual defense spending to around 10 trillion yen ($68 billion) by 2027, which would make Japan the world's third-biggest military spender after the United States and China.

Defense Minister Minoru Kihara announced in December a decision to accelerate deployment of some Tomahawks and Japanese-made Type 12 surface-to-ship missiles beginning in fiscal year 2025, a year before the original plan.

The government says Japan is facing its "severest" security environment since World War II because of threats from China and North Korea, causing it to increase military cooperation with the U.S., Australia, Britain and other friendly nations.

In November, the U.S. approved a $2.35 billion sale of two types of Tomahawks — 200 Block IV missiles and 200 upgraded Block V versions.

They can be launched from warships and hit targets 1,600 kilometers (1,000 miles) away, officials said.

The signing of the purchase agreement on Thursday was attended by Kihara and U.S. Ambassador to Japan Rahm Emanuel.

Japan and the United States agreed to expedite the deployment "in response to the increasingly severe security environment," Kihara said.

Emanuel said training of Japanese service members for the Tomahawks will start in March.

Govt crafting policies to raise power consumption

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha said that the government was working at policy-making levels to increase internal consumption of domestically produced electricity.

Inaugurating the 24th anniversary of Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) on Thursday, Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha stressed on the need of increasing investment from both the government and private sector for the overall development and promotion of hydropower sector.

Mentioning that the private sector is contributing to the country by investing in the hydropower sector, he said that until a few years ago, there was a 16-hour daily power cut, but now the country is exporting surplus energy.

Shrestha said that the energy producers are not only doing business but also contributing significantly to the country's development.

It is not enough to generate energy and do business only, he said and stressed on the need to expand the area of its domestic consumption.

He said that although an agreement has been inked with India to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity in 10 years, the issue of increasing domestic consumption has been the main priority. He said that if the concept of green development can be adopted now, the country will move ahead on the path of economic development.



DPM Shrestha urged the investors to invest confidently as the government is committed to ensure the security for the investment. He said that the government was planning how to advance the energy sector in the investment conference to be held next April.

Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha said that along with the development of energy, the development of tourism, agriculture and infrastructure will also be taken together for making Nepal prosperous. "After the epoch-making political changes, the focus of the nation is to accelerate economic growth. So, the present government is fully focused on ensuring good governance, prosperity and social justice," he said.

He said that the first priority of the government was to bring the economy on track and to accelerate the pace of growth by increasing economic activities.

"There is no doubt that remittance inflows have been contributing to the national economy. We know that the country's economy should not be fully dependent on remittance for a self-reliant economy. But, there is also no way to stop foreign migrant workers immediately. We have to gradually reduce the flow of people going abroad for work," he said.

In the event, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet said that the private sector's contribution to energy development is about 60 to 70 per cent.

He said that the government was trying to meet the demand of the private sector and after meeting the demand of the private sector, it will help to increase energy generation.

Minister Basnet said that the private sector had the biggest role in peaking the production capacity from 800 to 2,900 MW in the last decade.

He said that the government was committed to provide support to the private sector with a commitment that they will do so much.

Stating that the government has planned to generate about 28,500 MW electricity by 2035, he said that the present scenario of power generation showed that the country would not only meet this target but also surpass it.

On the occasion, IPPAN President Ganesh Karki said that energy entrepreneurs are excited from the latest long-term power trade agreement between Nepal and India to sell 10,000 megawatts of electricity in 10 years.

"Now the country has become energy hub. I request the government to declare the next decade as an energy decade," he said.

Stating that the government had now increased the VAT in the energy sector, President Karki said that they are demanding with the government to maintain the previous rate.

"Regarding the reduction of VAT in the energy sector, the Ministry of Finance has suggested that the Ministry of Energy take a proposal to the Cabinet to solve the problem," he said. "We are confident that this problem will be solved by the Ministry of Energy."

He said that 31 projects have been damaged due to floods and landslides and also asked to solve the problems of those projects.

Stating that about Rs. 4,600 billion will be invested to produce 10,000 megawatts of electricity, he asked the Nepal Rastra Bank to pay attention to increase investment from banks and financial institutions in this sector.

On the occasion, the IPPAN honoured individuals and institutions recognising their contribution in the field of hydropower development.

Ministry begins discussion on labour migration policy

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

The Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security has begun discussion with experts and stakeholders on initial draft of the labour migration policy.

During the discussion programme the Ministry organized, Labour Minister Sharat Singh Bhandari, informed that government was for a policy on labour migration in order to make the domestic and foreign employment dignified.

The policy is also essential for promoting and incorporating labour issues in the forthcoming five-year plan and making systematic this sector, he added.

Secretary Kewal Prasad Bhandari informed that the draft would be amended based on the suggestions garnered by the taskforce.

The Ministry is effortful to ensure health and social security as major agenda in the labour migration policy.

The stakeholders and experts furnished suggestions during the programme.

The government had formed a taskforce under the coordination of labour expert Dr Ganesh Gurung to draft the labour migration policy. The taskforce has begun discussion on the draft policy.

DUDHKOSHI JALVIDYUT COMPANY LIMITED
(A Subsidiary Company of Nepal Electricity Authority)
DUDHKOSHI STORAGE HYDROELECTRIC PROJECT

INVITATION FOR CONSULTATIVE MEETING
with PROSPECTIVE INTERNATIONAL CONSULTING FIRMS/COMPANIES/ORGANIZATIONS for Consultancy Services for Project Construction Supervision of DKSHEP

First Date of Publication:- 19 January 2024

1. Dudhkoshi Storage Hydroelectric Project (DKSHEP) with capacity of 635 MW is a seasonal reservoir based project located in Khotang, Okhaldhunga and Solukhumbu Districts of Koshi Province, Nepal. It is a multi-billion dollar project and is highly prioritized by Government of Nepal (GoN). Dudhkoshi Jalvidyut Company Limited (DKJVCL) has been established on 03 March 2017 (2073/11/20 B.S.) as a subsidiary company of Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) for the implementation of DKSHEP.
2. The Updated Feasibility Study and Detailed Design of the Project and preparation of Bidding Documents along with EIA Study are being carried out by ELC Electroconsult S.p.A. (Italy) in association with NEWJEC Inc. (Japan) since 2016 under Asian Development Bank (ADB)'s grant assistance through Project Preparatory Facility for Energy. These reports and documents are in the final stage of completion. The Government of Nepal (GoN) has requested ADB to be the Lead Financier of this Project and all procurement will follow ADB's Procurement Regulations once the financing arrangements are confirmed.
3. It is expected that Invitation for Expressions of Interest (EoI) for this consultancy services will be published in Q2-2024. The duration of the consultancy services is likely to be in the order of 9 years including 2 years of post commissioning period.
4. In this context, DKJVCL intends to organize a **Consultative Meeting** with interested international consulting firms/companies/organizations for "Consultancy Services for Project Construction Supervision of DKSHEP" with the primary objective of providing project information and interacting and seeking participants' feedbacks/suggestions on scopes of consultancy services for project construction supervision. Following are the main objectives of this meeting:
   a. inform the prospective international consulting firms about DKSHEP, project features and implementation plan,
   b. share the proposed contract packaging options for civil, hydro-mechanical, electro-mechanical and transmission line and seek the advice from the consulting firms thereon,
   c. share the requirements of team of specialists and experts having international experiences in relevant project components such as CFRD (Concrete Faced Rock-fill Dam), tunnels, underground powerhouse, hydro-mechanical & electro-mechanical works, 400 kV double circuit transmission line etc. similar to DKSHEP,
   d. get feedbacks/suggestions on scopes of consultancy services, terms of reference (ToR), EoI, RFP, Conditions of Contract (CoC), including payment conditions, total requirements of team of specialists and experts, implementation plan, etc.
5. Meeting will be held both virtually and physically on following date, time and venue:
   a. Date:- 07 February 2024, Wednesday
   b. Time:- 15:00-17:00 hours, Nepal Standard Time (NST)
   c. Venue:- to be confirmed by email/phone
   It is strongly advised to international consulting firms or their representatives to attend the meeting physically. With a view to ensure effective participation and meaningful discussions, it is recommended that consulting firms may depute upto a maximum of three representatives for the physical meeting. Firms planning to attend virtually may please use one username only. The link for the meeting will be shared well in advance. Participants are requested to join the meeting physically / virtually at least 20 minutes before the scheduled time. Late admission will not be allowed.
6. In order to make the meeting productive, interested consulting firms/companies/organisations are requested to confirm their participations by 02 February 2024, Friday, 15:00 hours NST (Nepal Standard Time) and send any questions or queries to discuss or interact in the meeting in the following official email account within the same date and time (i.e., 02 February 2024).
7. Further information of the Project and proposed meeting may be obtained on the following web page or from following email on request.

Address
Dudhkoshi Jalvidyut Company Limited (DKJVCL)
Dudhkoshi Storage Hydroelectric Project (DKSHEP)
United World Trade Centre, Tripureshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal
Phone no: 01-5917089, 5917137
Web: www.nea.org.np, Email: dkoshi@nea.org.np

400 students of 40 districts studying in Waling technical school

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Jan. 18

It may seem strange that students from 40 districts are studying at the technical school of a village in Waling, Syangja district. The ' Farmer's Multi Technical School' of Chapakot Municipality-10, which has been providing quality education to prepare technical manpower, is now the talk of the town.

Established to improve the overall quality of life of the youth through professional and employment-oriented skills, the school has been able to make the desired progress in a short time. The Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training established it as an affiliated school in 2018. The school teaches courses in four subjects--agriculture, animal health, biology and engineering (information technology and civil engineering).

Around 400 students are now studying these subjects. For the farmers from 40 different districts, including Syangja, it has become the only place to study.



The school has produced more than 100 skilled technicians in technical agriculture and engineering and has provided more than 1,000 people with skill-based training, which made them eligible to get employment immediately.

Jeevan Prasad Bhandari, head of the school, said that technical education has become a good place for students from geographically remote places and ethnically and economically backward communities.

Bhandari said that students from many districts are studying in the school as they can get technical education enjoying the facilities of reservation, concession and free scholarship. According to him, students from 60 districts have come to study in the school so far. The school provides education of three natures, he said, It has been producing skilled engineers and imparts short-term skill-based training.

The school has become a boon for those who have learned skills in different ways but have not been able to prove the gained skills.

They have been provided certificates in coordination with the National Skill Testing Committee.

Dev Bahadur Khand (Ishwor), Mayor of Chapakot Municipality. said that the local government was taking initiatives for the construction of a well-equipped building for the school.

Minister for Justice, Law and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung, who visited the school to monitor it recently, said that he would facilitate for the formulation of necessary laws required to make technical education easily accessible.

Minister Gurung stressed the need for quality education stating that technical education is needed to get employment immediately.

Bhandari briefed Minister Gurung about the challenges, requirements and immediate steps to be taken in running the school smoothly.

Govt working to reduce digital divide: Minister Sharma

It has been a year since the present government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' assumed office. The government has accorded high priority to the implementation of constitution, strengthening of federalism, economic recovery and reform, investment promotion, employment creation, improved public service delivery with citizen-friendly governance, corruption control and introduction and implementation of laws, policies and programmes. In this regard, **Rekha Sharma**, leading the Ministry of Communications and Information Technology largely responsible for bridging government and people, has played a significant role in forwarding government policies and priorities with their proper implementation. She has also taken initiatives to bring reform in communication and IT sectors in the changed context.

The following is the edited version of an interview Minister Sharma and the Spokesperson of the government gave to **Krishna Adhikari**, Feature News Chief, and journalist **Ashok Ghimire** from Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS).



PHOTO: RSS

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma.

It has been a year since the present government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' came to power. What are the efforts from your side to translate people's hope of good governance, prosperity and social justice into action?

The government has been working actively for good governance, prosperity and social justice since its formation a year back. In line with the commitment made by Prime Minister 'Prachanda', the government has taken firm actions to realise effective service delivery and economic prosperity. New initiatives were launched to maintain good governance. During this period, government actions on fake Bhutanese refugees, Lalita Niwas land grab, gold smuggling, loan sharking and citizenship issues were exemplary ones. These actions are solid examples that all are equal before the law, and lawlessness is not accepted. The federal democratic republic is a people's system and no one has the right to indulge in wrong deeds. It is a further testament that anyone involved in wrongdoing faces legal action.

People were facing much hassle even for receiving common services. Farmers were deprived of chemical fertilisers in time, resulting in decline in agro production. But, this past year saw no shortage of fertilisers and seeds, which contributed well to a historic increase in rice production. Equally worth mentioning is the availability of textbooks to students at community schools this year. The textbooks were supplied to all schools before the start of the academic year. The compulsion of people standing in line for hours to receive 'No objection letter', driving licenses and passports also ended. The slack public service delivery has changed to ensure relief to citizens.

However, the PM, during the evaluation of the government's one year in office, commented that the government's performance was not up to the mark. It is his decency to admit government performance is still slow off the mark and commitment to improvement.

The government has continued efforts to protect political achievements and conclude transitional justice via national consensus. Overall, the government's activities in the last one year have made people hopeful.

What are MoCIT's priorities in the sector of good governance and service delivery?

This Magh 3 (Jan 17) is the day I completed one year in office. The IT sector is changing every day, but laws are too old to regulate new dimensions of mass communications. I attached priority to law-making. Cyber security has emerged as a new challenge, for which to address, we brought Cyber Security Policy. Even a Directive on the Use and Operation of Social Network Sites was issued. Bills on Media Council and Mass Communications are under consideration. Frequency Policy has been drafted. The regulation relating to property management of telecommunication service providers which have not renewed licenses was amended. The Advertisement Regulation was also amended in a bid to strengthen communications by making advertisement market transparent. Many issues relating to the ministry and its subordinate agencies were left unaddressed for years. Some even prompted written complaints. Investigation was launched on these issues. One among those was a complaint on tax evasion by ISPs, to which we probed. Similarly, an investigation into the non-implementation of ADMS has been concluded. These initiatives are catalysts to ensure good governance to the people. Wrongdoers are not spared; we are aware that no one would be involved in breaking the rules.

> The IT sector is changing every day, but laws are too old to regulate new dimensions of mass communications. I attached priority to law-making. Cyber security has emerged as a new challenge, for which to address, we brought Cyber Security Policy.

Guarantee of quality IT service along with citizen's access to service is present urgency. How is the Ministry advancing activities to minimize the 'digital divide'?

Of course, guarantee of quality service delivery is imperative to reduce digital divide. Digital divide is caused due to peoples' deprivation of IT access. The Ministry has forwarded together the awareness and capacity building of youths on how IT could be utilised for income generation. Via Nepal Telecommunications Authority (NTA), various programmes such as 'youth tech expo' and 'digital champion' were launched to entice youths to IT. Even an IT exhibition is in the offing. We are planning to conduct nationwide IT training. Once these activities are conducted, it will certainly help reduce the digital divide.

Needless to explain, IT has significant role on service delivery. Model districts are announced via Nepal Telecom in a bid to improve IT quality and access to IT. In this regard, 19 districts including quake-hit Jajarkot and Rukum West have been declared model districts and implementation units set up. It counts much in providing service in the far-flung villages. IT infrastructures have been dubbed prerequisite to prosperity by the Ministry. High-speed internet has already been expanded to 74 districts. Dolpa and Humla are getting internet service within this fiscal year. Mugu is in the list for next year. The laying down of optical fibres along the Mid-Hill Highway has been intensified. It is over in the Koshi Province; is going to be completed in Sudurpaschim and Karnali Provinces soon, while Gandaki and Lumbini Provinces have witnessed legal snags with court cases. The Ministry has written to the courts, requesting them to accord prior rights to the pending cases and conclude them soon. It bears significance in terms of service dispensing. The ministry is working for it.

What's your observation on Nepal's IT service, production and export potential?

Once the eight sectors envisioned by the Digital Nepal Framework-- digital infrastructure, agriculture, health, education, energy, tourism, economy and urban infrastructures-- are developed, Nepal can realise a huge success. However, it is worrying that implementation status of Digital Nepal Framework introduced in 2076BS is poor. We're trying how it can be made effective. In a year, we can realise some changes in IT sectors.

Restructuring of state-run media has surfaced for long. How are you forwarding it?

Organisational restructuring is essential both at the ministry and its subordinate bodies. The bill relating to public service broadcasting is under discussion at the parliament committee. Once the bill is passed, Nepal Television and Radio Nepal will undergo restructuring. Restructuring is not an emotional subject. It needs a certain rule. Similarly, a draft of the Media Council Bill has been forwarded to the Law Ministry for study. Consensus is being built on the draft of the Mass Communications Bill. Both of these are being taken to the Cabinet.

We are planning to make Gorkhapatra and its sister publications worth reading. The Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS) is a news bank. RSS has recently launched a news service in the mother language. The mother languages are gradually being included and increased in the State-run media. The RSS must be developed as a media house capable of producing news for the media in the country and abroad.

State-run media are not mere media of panegyric. They must act as bridges between the government and the people. Their role is important to share people's problems with government and reach the government's good initiatives to the people.

> State-run media are not mere media of panegyric. They must act as bridges between the government and the people. Their role is important to share people's problems with government.

What are the ways to relate social sites to income generation and the livelihood of citizens?

A society without the presence and use of social sites has become unimaginable now. However, the consequences of the misuse of social sites are cause for concern, and the issue should be addressed amidst these situations. The Ministry has issued 'Directive on Use and Management of Social Networking Sites' in the absence of a dedicated policy regarding social sites.

The Directive highlights the dos and don'ts for social site users. The drafting of a bill aiming to systematise social sites has neared the final phase. We wish to ensure the participation of mass stakeholders in the process of enacting laws. On the one hand, the potentiality of connecting social sites to income generation should be considered positively, while on the other hand, we have to gear up to curb their misuse.

What are the plans of the Ministry to internationalise Nepal's identity through films?

Film, being a source of entertainment, remains one of the most effective means of communication. It is capable of reflecting the real situation of the time and can be used as a tool to convey messages to society. Nepali films should be connected to our customs, culture, and languages. First of all, they should be competitive in the internal market. The Ministry is working to make the Film Act, 2026BS abreast with time. The role of the Nepal Film Board is vital in promoting the Nepali film industry.

If we could arrange film shooting in tourist spots, it could have a huge impact on the international film industry. The process of establishing a film city in Dolakha has been initiated. Overall, Nepal itself is like a hub for filmmaking due to its natural beauty. The Ministry plans to attract the international community to choose Nepal for cinematography and increase the quality and standards of Nepali films.

It is said that the absence of security printing at home causes a huge capital and information flight. What endeavours is the Ministry undertaking to ensure security printing facilities at home?

Security printing services should be available within the country, as it is related to the country's prestige. Bearing in mind the cost the country faces while seeking security printing services from outside the country, a bill regarding security printing is in the Parliament. Unfortunately, whatever works are carried out in security printing in Nepal, they are questioned by the regulatory bodies. We are committed to finalising the bill in this regard as soon as possible.

What are the ways to make the postal service relevant and effective in the changing context?

The postal service cannot sustain in a traditional way. In government policies, programmes and the budget, the provision of additional post offices has been scrapped, and the concept of 'one municipality, one post office' has been forwarded. The Ministry plans to provide 'smart postal services.' Advancements in road infrastructure, vehicles, and information technology have demanded transformations in postal services. Regulations regarding additional post offices are in the process of decision. The postal service should be enriched by IT innovations as per the needs of time.

Finally, what programmes capable of addressing people's needs and concerns directly are the Ministry introducing ahead based on the experiences of one year in office?

The MoCIT is the body to represent the contemporary era and generation. Information, technology, and mass communications can influence the conscious and youth generation the most. After one year of experience in the office, I am quite confident that this is the time for a departure in IT, and in the absence of such a departure, it would not open avenues for the prosperity of the nation.

It is necessary to have proper policies, programmes, and budget management to establish the IT sector as an indispensable part of prosperity. We have realized IT is an emergency service and the field capable of competing globally. Transformations in IT will transform people's lives. Deliveries in IT are possible by staying within the country.

The development of the IT sector will lead to the creation of more jobs, discouragement to youth exodus for employment and encouragement to the return of those who have been abroad for career opportunities. In the end, I expect impartial assessments of the Ministry from all quarters. I hope such evaluations will provide moral strength for the Ministry to perform more substantively in the days to come.

Committee formed to negotiate cable car construction issue



PHOTO: TRN

Mukkumlung Joint Struggle Committee members in Pathivara area.

BY CHANDRA PANDAK
Taplejung, Jan. 18

A committee has been formed to engage in negotiations with the parties that are protesting against the construction of a cable car project in the Pathibhara area of Taplejung district.

A nine-member negotiation committee, led by Tshiring Lama, Chief of the District Coordination Committee in Taplejung, has been formed to address the concerns raised by the groups opposing the cable car construction project.

An all-party meeting held in coordination with the Pathibhara Area Development Committee on Wednesday decided to form a committee under the coordination of Lama.

According to Prajin Hangmang, the Executive Director of the Pathibhara Area Development Committee, Mayor of Fungling Municipality Amir Maden, Chairperson of Pathibhara Yangwar Rural Municipality Keshar Kumar Subba, Chairperson of Siriganga Rural Municipality Lal Krishna Chauhan, Chairperson of Faktanglung Rural Municipality Rajan Limbu (Mukti), Chairperson of Pathibhara Area Development Committee Rakki Thebe, and Chief District Officer Heera Devi Poudel are members in the negotiation committee.

Hangmang informed that a decision was made to appoint Rudra Prasad Poudel, a member of Pathibhara Mukkumlung Cable Car Private Limited, as the member secretary of the committee.

The Pathibhara area spreads in Phungling Municipality, Pathibhara Yangbarak, Paktanglung and Sirijungha rural municipalities.

The committee is tasked with the responsibility of resolving the issue through negotiations with the Mukkumlung Joint Struggle Committee and the Cable Car Project Cancellation Struggle Committee.

Under the leadership of Chandra Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industries, a proposal to build the cable car project in Pathibhara was forwarded. All necessary procedures, including the Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the cable car project, have been finalised.

As the process of initiating the project implementation reaches its final stage, the Mukkumlung Joint Struggle Committee and the Cable Car Project Cancellation Struggle Committee are gearing up to strongly oppose the project. In response, a negotiation committee has been established to seek a resolution to the impending issue.

On the other hand, the agitating group, which has started a protest against the cable car project, is now conducting activities to block the work in the area.

The agitating group has been circulating a message in the Pathibhara area for the past few days that they would not allow the work to begin. They have been saying that they will strongly resist the construction of the cable car project.

Free eye camp in Khajura, Nepalgunj

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 18

A free health camp conducted in Khajura Rural Municipality, located in the western part of Banke district, successfully provided free eye examinations to 1,127 individuals. The event, coordinated by Nepal Netra Jyoti Sangh, Fateh-Bal Eye Hospital Nepalgunj and Khajura covered all wards of the rural municipality.

Umer Ahmad Sadiq, the Programme Officer of Fateh-Bal Eye Hospital, reported that among the 1,127 people examined during the camp held from January 7 to 17, a total of 284 individuals were identified with cataracts in one eye. These cases have been referred to Fateh-Bal Eye Hospital Nepalgunj for subsidised eye surgery.

Expressing gratitude, Programme Officer Sadiq acknowledged the significant contribution of the staff and volunteers of the related health posts to ensuring the success of the free eye camps.

Dr. Kaushal Kumar Verma, Managing Director of Fateh-Bal Eye Hospital, commended the support received from health posts' personnel for their role in effectively promoting and supporting the free eye camps organised across all wards. He emphasised the importance of such initiatives in addressing eye health issues in the community.

> Expressing gratitude, Programme Officer Sadiq acknowledged the significant contribution of the staff and volunteers of the related health posts to ensuring the success of the free eye camps.

Looking ahead, Managing Director Verma announced plans to continue the free eye camp campaign. The next camp is scheduled to take place in all wards of Baijanath Rural Municipality from January 21 to 24, aiming to extend the positive impact of the initiative to a broader community.

The free health camp in Khajura Rural Municipality has not only identified and addressed eye health concerns but also demonstrated the commitment of healthcare providers and volunteers towards improving the well-being of the community.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Happiness does not lie in happiness, but in the achievement of it.
- Fyodor Dostoevsky

EDITORIAL

Waterbird Conservation

In a worrying trend, the number of visiting waterbirds has declined in the Narayani River area. A waterbird named Ruddy Shelduck, commonly called Chakhewa in Nepali, used to be found in abundance along the Narayani River towards Nawalpur until last year, but their number has taken a 50 per cent dive this year. In the 2021 bird census, 47 bird species were sighted in the area. That number dropped to only 37 in 2022. The year 2023 saw a slight increase of the number to 43, only to drop to 41 this year. Surprisingly, eight bird species observed last year were not present this year. But here is also a share of good news: the Eurasian Wigeon (Sindhure Hans), Common Pochard (Kailetauke Hans), Kentish Plover (Alak Chandra Raj Putrika), Wood Sandpiper (Ban Sud Sudia), and Dunlin (Thulo Jal Rang) were observed for the first time in the Narayani River, which were absent during last year's bird count.

Experts chiefly blame a range of anthropogenic activities in and around the wetlands that have spoiled or destroyed their habitat, as well as climate change, for this. What's more, disruptions in their migratory routes, likely caused by changes in the environment is said to be another factor. The rivers are getting increasingly polluted with the daily mixing of sewage and garbage into water sources, causing water bodies to dry up and exacerbating the problem. Conservation experts have pointed out the recent uptick in illegal poaching in our national parks and wetlands as another cause for the decline.

A total of 162 bird species inhabit the water areas of Nepal. Out of the overall avian population, more than 200 species are reliant on water, including 100 species categorised as visiting birds. During winter, the winged guests seek refuge in wetlands near rivers. Every year, migratory birds from Siberia, China, Russia, Mongolia, Thailand, Korea, Burma, and other countries arrive to the river and its surrounding areas during this time mainly to evade extreme cold in the places where they come from.

Wetlands are a crucial part of the ecosystem that regulate water and play a unique role in keeping the food chain intact. They are also habitats for several species of wildlife, from aquatic animals to migratory birds. Spread from high mountains to lowland plains, they support a variety of ecosystems. A crucial source of freshwater, they also breathe life into many critically important biodiversity, providing sanctuary to many endangered species. Many of such areas are so culturally and religiously significant to so many people that they form the basis of their identities, not to mention the source of livelihoods.

Given this, it's incumbent upon the government as well as every citizen to spring into action to reverse the trend. The former must adopt stringent policy measures that not only go a long way to stop poachers of all stripes to rear their ugly heads again and again, but also to strongly put all natural resources at the centre. Preserving their pristine condition as well as sanctity must take precedence over everything else, tourism included. The reason: once they are gone for good, the damage done is irreversible. That also amount to losing our national heritage – the source of national pride. The time to act in now!

EBC In Spotlight

BINI DAHAL

There is no denying that Nepal is defined by the culture of its people and natural resources, especially high snow-clad mountains. They are considered unique treasures of the nation. Since the first human ascent of Sagarmatha in 1953, Nepal has come to limelight internationally. Mountains have significantly contributed to building the country's position as a major tourist destination in the globe.

Sagarmatha (Mt. Everest), standing at an elevation of 8848.86 metres above sea level, is the most popular destination among mountaineers and nature lovers from around the world. A journey to the Khumbu Region is quite challenging and adventurous. A trip to Everest Base Camp (EBC) also remains a memorable journey for many adventurers.

The Himalaya region has become a location where people from home and abroad create and break records. A four-year-old girl from the Czech Republic has now gained popularity far and wide after it was found that she became the youngest person to reach EBC. Zara along with her father and her seven year-old brother has enjoyed her tour to EBC. Visiting EBC is not an easy task as it is located at a height of 5,364 metre above sea level. One has to complete a long trek to EBC from Lukla in a difficult terrain with high chances of suffering from altitude-related ailments.

Previously, a five-year-old girl named Prisha Lokesh Nikajoo had set the world record by reaching EBC. That record has now been broken by four-year-old Zara. Getting to such an altitude is not a difficult task. It can have potential harm to the body as at times we are unable to cope with altitude sicknesses. This can even push the body towards death. This is not just the case for young people but it can happen to those belonging to any age group. Obviously young and old age people are the most vulnerable ones.

This record is extraordinary and can surely help boost Nepal's mountain tourism. The government of Nepal has recently published a report saying how Nepal's tourism is bouncing back. However, tourist arrivals to Nepal have yet to reach the pre-pandemic level. With these kinds of records, more tourists would be interested in visiting the Nepal Himalayas to take up the risk.

However, this increasing popularity also puts a huge responsibility on the country for ensuring proper tourism management. We have read how during the spring season a long line of mountaineers are found climbing Sagarmatha. And there have been instances where while climbing atop people have lost their lives due to the overcrowding and drop of oxygen in their cylinders.

The most concerning matter is about growing climate change and its environmental repercussions. There were reports of the EBC and its vicinity areas losing a lot of glaciers owing to climate change and increased human activities. And even possibilities of changing the location of the base camp had been discussed. However, this idea was dropped later on due to the opposition from trekking communities.

As mentioned above, mountains are treasures not just for Nepal and also for the world. The government must come up with an extensive plan to manage mountain tourism effectively and strictly implement its plans and policies. To ensure sustainability of the tourism sector, we will have to put much effort into protecting the mountains. This way people will be able to set more records and the tourism industry will become more robust and more importantly the country's progress and growth will be substantial.

Hydropower For Speedy Growth



Lok Deep Thapa

Nepal is a nation gifted by nature for its beauty. Within its small area, it has the lofty Himalayan range, which houses the tallest mountain of the world, Mt. Everest. Then it has the green hilly areas in the middle, where people of different ethnicity live with their own distinct type of culture and even languages. Down south in the lowlands, it has the lush Terai area, with more different people, and this area can virtually be called the 'bread-basket' of the country. Nepal has such diversity within a very short distance.

When we talk of the beauty of Nepal, we cannot make the mistake of missing out the name of Kathmandu Valley, which is not only rich in its culture, but also has its famous temples and historic monuments. In fact it is said many museums in the Valley are only a stone's throw away from one another in many places. It probably has the most number of UNESCO-recognised heritage sites within a very small area. This may sound like being repetitive, but like one cannot forget Kathmandu while talking about the beauty and attraction of Nepal, the Newar community cannot be forgotten when talking about Kathmandu, because of the rich cultural heritage, bountiful fields and unique cuisines of this city. People from all over Nepal come to Kathmandu to get a taste of the lip smacking cuisine of the Newar community here, which can be found in small side streets and also in expensive eateries at many places.

Rich heritage

In fact the rich cultural heritage, intricate handicraft and temples that adorn most parts of the city were mostly developed during the Malla dynasty of the Newar community. Whether some people like it or not, we must not hesitate to praise the kings of the Malla period for making Kathmandu, Bhaktapur and Lalitpur the heritage wise rich places they are now, centuries after the dynasty was replaced.

Now to come back to the present, it is not only now, but it has been several decades since the economy of the country has been seeing a downward trend. So this government alone cannot be blamed for the woes that the nation is seeing now. Many so-called experts even predicted that Nepal would turn into another Sri Lanka. But what they did not mention was that Sri Lanka as an island nation not only has access to the oceans from all sides, but it also has a sound infrastructure in all sectors so that it could quickly bounce back, though it saw some really hard times recently as far as its economy was concerned.

Nepal is a landlocked nation and the situation of this Himalayan country is almost exactly opposite to that of Sri Lanka. The steadily weakening value of its currency is an indicator that the nation's economy is suffering. So, it is high time that the top leaders, especially those who are in power, the bureaucrats and the planners accept the fact that hydropower and tourism

> The small scale industries and local level enterprises also cannot be overlooked, as they are enabling thousands of people to make a living and also providing service to consumers.

are the two strong pillars of national economy, among others, which could make the weakening economy pull through and bring in better times for the majority of the people.

Nepal has already signed an agreement with India to export ten thousand mega-watts of electricity to that country within a period of ten years. It is further encouraging to learn that similar agreements are in the pipeline with Bangladesh and China as well, in fact, they are almost at a final stage. Such agreements and the ability to sell electricity to other countries would be of enormous help to reduce the huge deficits Nepal is still suffering in its trade with foreign countries. It is just that leaders and others should show more vision in tapping the huge natural potential Nepal possesses.

Similarly, the country has also seen a leap forward in the arrival of tourists after the slump faced by the travel sector in almost all countries of the world due to the Corona virus. Kathmandu sees the arrival of many foreign airlines bringing in passengers from all over the world. However, the public-private partnership has not been able to take off. Just some officials going abroad in the name of tourism promotion is simply not enough. Similarly, the private sector which makes a tidy profit from tourism must also contribute in making more successful this enterprise.

Job opportunities

Tourism is in fact a sector, which could not only benefit the government and make the economy strong, but it could also keep back the thousands of youths who are presently going out of the country for better job opportunities abroad. Tourism would also contribute largely for the accumulation of our foreign currency reserves which the country needs badly because it relies heavily on foreign imports.

Like the hydro-power and tourism sectors, agriculture also has a huge potential in Nepal, as has been proved by many individuals who have come back to their own country and invested here. This would also be able to provide much opportunities to youths and they would prefer to stay back in their homes while earning a comfortable income as well. The small scale industries and local level enterprises also cannot be overlooked, as they are enabling thousands of people to make a living and also providing service to consumers which other economically failed states have not been able to provide. However, it is important for the government to prioritise its focus on the above mentioned sectors, which could help the nation get out of the present economic problems it is facing now.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

Nepal's Evolving Tourism Landscape



Sudhan Subedi

In the dynamic realm of global tourism, Nepal has emerged as a beacon of successful public-private collaboration with the establishment of the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB) two and a half decades ago. This article delves into the transformative journey of the NTB, spotlighting its pivotal role in surpassing the one million tourist arrivals milestone, executing innovative campaigns, and setting ambitious targets for attracting two million tourists annually.

Founded in 1998, the NTB was conceived as a joint effort between the private sector and the government to invigorate tourism in Nepal. Early initiatives, such as the Destination Nepal Campaign in 2002/2003, the Mount Everest Golden Jubilee Celebrations, aimed to position Nepal as a diverse and appealing destination beyond Kathmandu's borders. For instance, the Destination Nepal Campaign strategically showcased Nepal's cultural richness, adventure offerings, and serene landscapes in international forums, contributing to a significant surge in tourist interest.

Strategic celebrations

Throughout its journey, the NTB strategically celebrated the Year of Tourism in 1998, 2011, and 2020. These celebratory years not only positioned Nepal globally but also diversified tourism, showcasing the nation's tourism prowess. In response to the devastating earthquake, the 'Nepal Now' campaign demonstrated resilience globally, emphasising that tourism possibilities endured despite adversity. The 'Nepal Now' campaign, launched after the earthquake, showcased Nepal's resilience and commitment to tourism, conveying a powerful message that despite challenges, the country was ready to welcome visitors.

As the global economic downturn induced by the COVID-19 pandemic unfolded in 2020, Nepal's tourism sector faced unprecedented challenges. The NTB, an instrumental player in the country's tourism, grappled with the aftermath, prompting a crucial assessment of its role.

Despite Nepal welcoming foreign tourists for over seven decades, the tourism sector's progress has been gradual, with the reinstated multi-party system in 1991 opening doors for opportunities. Despite the challenges posed by the pandemic, the NTB leveraged digital platforms and virtual experiences to keep Nepal visible on the global tourism map.

Recognising the need for stability in a volatile political climate, discussions led by tourism experts and supported by the UNDP resulted in the establishment of the NTB in 1998. The early years witnessed commendable leadership in market promotion, earning recognition even from India and Sri Lanka. However, over time, the NTB struggled to maintain momentum and credibility.

Deviations from core objectives, adherence to public procurement laws, and external and internal politics highlighted challenges. Such challenges induced deviations from the original market-focused approach, with internal and external pressures affecting the

> The 'Nepal Now' campaign, launched after the earthquake, showcased Nepal's resilience and commitment to tourism, conveying a powerful message that despite challenges, the country was ready to welcome visitors.

board's ability to stay aligned with its core objectives.

Amidst economic challenges, the NTB faced criticisms from the private sector, accusing the management of misdirecting resources towards non-essential programmes instead of prioritising tourism promotion. Despite being identified by the government as a vital sector requiring robust support, the board allegedly prioritised unrelated programmes, jeopardizing active participation in vital tourism initiatives. The absence from prestigious events like WTM and ITB Berlin due to mismanagement raised concerns about the board's commitment to tourism development.

It is important to note that Nepal has been participating in these fairs before NTB's establishment from past 35 plus years. A stark example of mismanagement includes the alleged diversion of resources to non-essential programs, hindering the NTB's primary focus on tourism promotion. As the NTB commemorates 25 years, there's a collective call for reflection and action.

The private sector, integral to the NTB's inception, must unite to address past shortcomings. The board's role as a bridge between the government and the private sector necessitates transparent governance and a renewed commitment to objectives.

A collaborative effort between the government and private sector stakeholders could involve a reassessment of the NTB's structure and operations to ensure effective alignment with contemporary tourism needs. To reclaim its global standing, the NTB must prioritize international marketing, embracing innovation, and ensuring active participation in major fairs.

Coordinated efforts

Coordinated efforts between the private sector and the government are imperative for effective crisis management and implementing a new promotional strategy. An illustrative strategy for the NTB would involve harnessing the power of social media influencers to promote Nepal's unique tourism offerings and engage with a broader audience.

As Nepal's tourism sector confronts internal challenges and navigates post-pandemic recovery, the NTB's 25th anniversary signals a pivotal moment. Revitalisation through collaboration, transparent governance, and a renewed mission are essential. The success of Nepal's tourism industry hinges on unity among stakeholders and effective public-private partnerships, solidifying its position as an alluring global destination.

(Subedi is an officer at Nepal Tourism Board and involved in tourism-related academic activities.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 19, 1974

RNAC Flight To Jumla Cancelled

Kathmandu, Jan 18: The RNAC flight to Jumla was cancelled today because of snow at the airstrip there, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Protect Waterfowls In Narayani River



This is in reference to a news report titled *"Waterbirds decline in Narayani river"* published in your daily on Thursday.

According to the news report, the number of waterbirds have declined significantly in the east Nawalparasi region. This is because of the growing number of human activities and recent developments around the wetlands. The mixing of sewage and garbage into water resources have significantly damaged the natural habitat.

Also, natural reasons like the change in environment and the disruption of migratory routes is also a major issue. Apparently, owing to the destruction of wetlands, the number of waterbirds has gone down by 50 per cent. Waterbirds are very important to the ecosystem. With rising human activities such as pollution and development around natural habitats, these species are at high risk. Therefore, comprehensive plans will have to be developed and implemented.

The concerned authorities and stakeholders should work together to ensure the protection of these species and also ensure their habitat is well-protected. Human activities that degrade environment should be put under control. For this the local authorities should ensure wetlands and other water resources are well managed. Nature protection should remain the key focus of the people and the government.

Aakriti Pokharel
Lainchour, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A wealthy merchant of 84 married a 25 year old fashion model. They had a wonderful honeymoon in Aruba but, unfortunately, the old boy suffered a coronary and was hospitalized.

When his young wife came to see him, the old man said, "Sweetheart, your future has been taken care of regardless of what happens to me. You will have an income of $250,000 a year, my home in Palm Springs, my ranch in Texas, my Mercedes. You'll never need to worry about money."

"Oh, sweetheart, please don't talk that way," his young wife exclaimed. "You've been so good to me already. If you go, I'll be devastated. Oh, there must be something I can do to help you. Please, tell me what I can do?"

"Well," the old man gasped, "you can quit pinching the inlet tube to my oxygen supply for starters."

Pakistan launches retaliatory air strikes in Iran killing at least 9

AFP
Islamabad, Jan. 18

Pakistan said Thursday it carried out strikes against militant targets in Iran, with Tehran reporting a death toll of nine civilians after staging its own air raid in Pakistan earlier this week.

Nuclear-armed Pakistan and neighbouring Iran are both battling simmering insurgencies along their sparsely populated border regions.

The cross-border attacks add to multiple crises across the Middle East, with Israel waging a war against Hamas in Gaza and Huthi rebels in Yemen attacking commercial vessels in the Red Sea.

"This morning Pakistan undertook a series of highly coordinated and specifically targeted precision military strikes against terrorist hideouts" in Iran's Sistan-Baluchistan province, Pakistan's foreign ministry said.

It said the action was taken in light of "credible intelligence of impending large-scale terrorist activities", adding that "a number of terrorists were killed".

Iran's official IRNA news agency reported that at least three women and four children were killed in blasts around the city of Saravan in the country's southeast, later adding that two men had also died.

Iran's foreign ministry summoned Pakistan's charge d'affaires "for an explanation", according to the Tasnim news agency.

Tehran and Islamabad frequently accuse each other of allowing militants to operate from the other's territory to launch attacks, but it is rare that official forces on either side engage.



PHOTO: AFP

A police officer stands guard outside Pakistan's foreign ministry in Islamabad on January 18, 2024.

"Pakistan fully respects the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Islamic Republic of Iran," Islamabad's foreign ministry said.

"The sole objective of today's act was in pursuit of Pakistan's own security and national interest which is paramount and cannot be compromised."

Beijing said Thursday it was willing to mediate between Pakistan and Iran following the exchange of fire in their border region.

Map of Iran locating Saravan in Sistan-Baluchistan province, near where Pakistan conducted strikes on Thursday © Julia Han JANICKI / AFP

"The Chinese side sincerely hopes that the two sides can exercise calm and restraint and avoid an escalation of tension," foreign ministry spokeswoman Mao Ning told a regular press conference.

The United States on Wednesday condemned the Iranian strikes in Pakistan, Iraq and Syria. State Department spokesman Matthew Miller said Tehran had violated the "sovereign borders of three of its neighbours in just the past couple of days".

Pakistan's caretaker Prime Minister Anwar-ul-Haq Kakar will cut short his visit at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, "in view of the ongoing developments", foreign ministry spokesperson Mumtaz Zahra Baloch said in a press conference in Islamabad.

Hours before the strike, Kakar had met the Iranian foreign minister on the sidelines of the Davos summit and posed for photographs.

Baloch said no information had been shared with Pakistan ahead of Iran's earlier strike on its soil.

Iran staged missile and drone attacks on the Jaish al-Adl group late Tuesday, after launching attacks in Iraq and Syria against what Tehran called "anti-Iranian terrorist groups.

Islamabad said the attack in its territory killed "two innocent children".

Judge threatens to boot Trump from courtroom

AP
New York, Jan. 18

Donald Trump was threatened with expulsion from his Manhattan civil trial Wednesday after he repeatedly ignored a warning to keep quiet while writer E. Jean Carroll testified that he shattered her reputation after she accused him of sexual abuse.

Judge Lewis A. Kaplan told the former president that his right to be present at the trial will be revoked if he remains disruptive. After an initial warning, Carroll's lawyer said Trump could still be heard making remarks to his lawyers, including "it is a witch hunt" and "it really is a con job."

"Mr. Trump, I hope I don't have to consider excluding you from the trial," Kaplan said in an exchange after the jury was excused for lunch, adding: "I understand you're probably very eager for me to do that."

"I would love it," the Republican presidential front-runner shot back, shrugging as he sat between lawyers Alina Habba and Michael Madaio at the defense table. "I know you would. You just can't control yourself in these circumstances, apparently," Kaplan responded.

"You can't either," Trump muttered.

Afterward, Trump ripped the judge in brief remarks to reporters at an office building he owns near the courthouse. He called the Bill Clinton appointee "a nasty judge" and a "Trump-hating guy," echoing his own social media posts that Kaplan was "seething and hostile," and "abusive, rude, and obviously not impartial."



PHOTO: AP

E. Jean Carroll arrives at Manhattan federal court, Wednesday, Jan. 17, 2024, in New York.

Trump has made similar comments about the judge in another case: a state of New York lawsuit accusing him of inflating his property values to get better rates on insurance and loans.

On Wednesday, Judge Kaplan denied a request from Trump's lawyers that he step aside from the case involving Carroll, a long-time Elle magazine advice columnist.

Kaplan cracked down after Carroll lawyer Shawn Crowley complained for a second time that Trump could be heard "loudly saying things" throughout her testimony as he sat at the defense table, frequently tilting back and leaning over to speak with his lawyers.

Crowley suggested that if Carroll's lawyers could hear Trump from where they were sitting, about 12 feet (3.7 metres) from him, jurors might've been able to hear him, too. Some appeared to split their focus between Trump and the witness stand.

Israeli strike kills 16 in southern Gaza

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 18

An Israeli airstrike on a home killed 16 people, half of them children, in the southern Gaza town of Rafah, medics said early Thursday. The military continued to strike targets in areas of the besieged territory where it has told civilians to seek refuge.

There was meanwhile no word on whether medicines that entered the territory Wednesday as part of a deal brokered by France and Qatar had been distributed to dozens hostages with chronic illnesses who are being held by Hamas.

More than 100 days after Hamas triggered the war with its Oct. 7 attack, Israel continues to wage one of the deadliest and most destructive military campaigns in recent history, with the goal of dismantling the militant group that has ruled Gaza since 2007 and returning scores of captives.

The war has stoked tensions across the region, threatening to ignite other conflicts.

More than 24,000 Palestinians have been killed, some 85% of the narrow coastal territory's 2.3 million people have fled their homes, and the United Nations says a quarter of the population is starving.

Hundreds of thousands have heeded Israeli evacuation orders and packed into southern Gaza, where shelters run by the United Nations are overflowing and massive tent camps have gone up. But Israel has continued to strike what it says are militant targets in all parts of Gaza, often killing women and children.



PHOTO: AP

Smoke rises following Israeli bombardments in Khan Younis, southern Gaza Strip, Wednesday, Jan. 17, 2024.

Dr. Talat Barhoum at Rafah's el-Najjar Hospital confirmed the death toll from the strike in Rafah and said dozens more were wounded. Associated Press footage from the hospital showed relatives weeping over the bodies of loved ones.

"They were suffering from hunger, they were dying from hunger, and now they have also been hit," said Mahmoud Qassim, a relative of some of those who were killed.

Internet and mobile services in Gaza have been down for five days, the longest of several outages during the war, according to internet access advocacy group NetBlocks. The outages complicate rescue efforts and make it difficult to obtain information about the latest strikes and casualties.

The war has rippled across the Middle East, with Iran-backed groups attacking U.S. and Israeli targets. Low-intensity fighting between Israel and Hezbollah militants in Lebanon threatens to erupt into all-out war, and Houthi rebels in Yemen continue to target international shipping despite United States-led airstrikes.

Iran has launched a series of missile attacks targeting what it described as an Israeli spy base in Iraq and militant bases in Syria as well as in Pakistan, which carried out reprisal strikes against what it described as militant hideouts in Iran early Thursday.

It was not clear if the strikes in Syria and Pakistan were related to the Gaza war. But they showcased Iran's ability to carry out long-range missile attacks at a time of heightened tensions with Israel and the U.S., which has provided crucial support for the Gaza offensive and carried out its own strikes against Iran-allied groups in Syria and Iraq.

Israel has vowed to dismantle Hamas to ensure it can never repeat an attack like the one on Oct. 7. Militants burst through Israel's border defenses and stormed through several communities that day, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking around 250 hostage.

US launches fourth round of strikes on Houthi targets

AFP
Washington, Jan. 18

American forces targeted 14 missiles that were ready to launch in Yemen, the US military said Wednesday, after Washington re-designated the Iran-backed Houthi rebels as a "terrorist" entity for their attacks on merchant vessels.

The Houthis -- who have already faced multiple rounds of air strikes in response to their targeting of international shipping -- struck a US-owned bulk cargo carrier in the wake of the designation announcement, and vowed to continue attacks they say are in support of Palestinians in Gaza.

US forces "conducted strikes on 14 Iran-backed Houthi missiles that were loaded to be fired in Houthi-controlled areas in Yemen," Central Command (CENTCOM) said in a statement.

"These missiles on launch rails presented an imminent threat to merchant vessels and US Navy ships in the region and could have been fired at any time, prompting US forces to exercise their inherent right and obligation to defend themselves," CENTCOM said.

Earlier on Wednesday, the United States announced that it would return the Houthis to a list of "terrorist" entities. "The Department of State today is announcing the designation of Ansarallah, commonly referred to as the Houthis, as a Specially Designated Global Terrorist group, effective 30 days from today," Secretary of State Antony Blinken said in a statement.

"During the 30-day implementation delay, the US government will conduct robust outreach to stakeholders, aid providers, and partners who are crucial to facilitating humanitarian assistance and the commercial import of critical commodities in Yemen," he said.

US National Security Advisor Jake Sullivan said the designation "is an important tool to impede terrorist funding to the Houthis, further restrict their access to financial markets, and hold them accountable for their actions."

"If the Houthis cease their attacks in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, the United States will immediately reevaluate this designation," Sullivan said in a statement. The Houthis, however, said they will not call off their strikes.

"We will not give up targeting Israeli ships or ships heading towards ports in occupied Palestine... in support of the Palestinian people," the group's spokesman Mohammed Abdelsalam told Al Jazeera TV, adding that they would respond to new strikes on Yemen by the United States or Britain.

PRISM

World's oldest dog title under review

Leiria: Guinness World Records is reviewing the title for world's oldest dog, which was awarded to a Portuguese dog, after questions arose about the dog's age.

Bobi, a Rafeiro do Alentejo, a breed of livestock stock, reportedly was 30 years and 266 days old in February when Guinness World Records recognized him as the world's oldest living dog and the oldest dog ever. He died in October after celebrating his 31st birthday in May.

But Guinness World Records is reviewing the records after questions arose about Bobi's age, Wired, The Guardian and CNN reported.

The dog's age had been confirmed through a 1992 registration with the Veterinary Medical Service of the Municipality of Leiria and the Portuguese pet database SIAC.

German man drinks cup of coffee in 3.12 seconds

Frankfort: A German man broke a Guinness World Record when he downed a cup of coffee in 3.12 seconds.

The record-keeping organization announced Felix von Meibom earned the title for fastest time to drink a cup of coffee in Frankfort.

Von Meibom's time of 3.12 seconds shaved .05 seconds off the previous record, which was set by fellow German and serial record-breaker Andre Ortolf in 2021. A video of the successful attempt shows von Meibom chugging the mug of java while it is still hot and steaming.

(AP)

School approves Mideast cease-fire resolution

AP
Ann Arbor, Mich, Jan. 18

A public school district in Michigan approved a resolution calling for a bilateral cease-fire in the Israel-Hamas war while also encouraging its teachers to discuss the conflict in its classrooms following an emotionally charged meeting Wednesday.

The resolution approved by the Ann Arbor Public Schools board appears to be among the first times that a public school system in the United States has made such a statement on the international conflict.

It followed an over five-hour meeting that stretched into the early hours of Thursday after 120 people gave public comments in both support and opposition of the resolution.

Tensions remained high throughout the meeting in Ann Arbor, a community close to 40 miles (64 kilometres) west of Detroit and home to the University of Michigan. Similar tensions have been seen across the nation in response to the war in Gaza, which is now entering its fourth month following a deadly Oct. 7 attack by Hamas militants.



PHOTO: AP

Tasneem Madani speaks in favour of a resolution calling for a ceasefire in the Israel-Hamas war that the Ann Arbor Public Schools board was considering Wednesday, Jan. 17, 2024, at Pioneer High School in Ann Arbor, Mich.

The conflict has divided college campuses, where long-simmering tensions are occasionally erupting in violence and shattering the sense of safety that makes colleges hubs of free discourse. Dozens of U.S. cities, including Ann Arbor, have approved cease-fire resolutions that have no legal authority but reflect the pressure on local governments to speak up on the Israel-Hamas war,

The resolution passed in Ann Arbor was one of the first times that a public school system in Michigan had considered such a statement, said Don Wotruba, executive director at Michigan Association of School Boards, prior to the scheduled vote.

Public School in US state of Michigan

"What they're thinking about doing would be pretty rare, if not the first time. Particularly as it's related to a more international situation," Wotruba said.

The district "expresses support for a bilateral ceasefire in Gaza and Israel," according to the resolution, and "encourages educators within the Ann Arbor School District to facilitate informed and respectful dialogue about the conflict."

Four of the seven board members voted in favour of the resolution, with two abstaining from the vote. Rima Mohammad, who is Palestinian, had been one of the most outspoken members in support of it.

"This resolution says that kids who have names like mine are seen, heard and valued," Mohammad said just prior to the vote.

Some parents in the district, which holds nearly 17,000 students, had expressed outrage about the resolution, and a petition opposing it collected nearly 2,000 signatures. The petition said that the issue has taken resources away from other important matters such as hiring a new superintendent, which the district is without.

"This resolution does not help advance the quality of life of one single child in this district," said Daniel Sorkin, a parent of two students in the district who spoke out against the resolution Wednesday.

Tasneem Madani, a student teacher in the district, supported the resolution and stressed its importance, saying that "our students are watching us."

"It is my responsibility, particularly as an English teacher, to help students develop the skills to engage in informed academic dialogue in safe spaces," Madani said at Wednesday's meeting.

TODAY IN HISTORY

379 – Emperor Gratian elevates Flavius Theodosius at Sirmium to Augustus, and gives him authority over all the eastern provinces of the Roman Empire.
1788 – The second group of ships of the First Fleet arrive at Botany Bay.
1795 – The Batavian Republic is proclaimed in the Netherlands, replacing the Dutch Republic.
1817 – An army of 5,423 soldiers, led by General José de San Martín, crosses the Andes from Argentina to liberate Chile and then Peru.
1829 – Johann Wolfgang von Goethe's Faust: The First Part of the Tragedy receives its premiere performance.
1839 – The British East India Company captures Aden.
1853 – Giuseppe Verdi's opera Il trovatore receives its premiere performance in Rome.
1883 – The first electric lighting system employing overhead wires, built by Thomas Edison, begins service at Roselle, New Jersey.

PARLIAMENTARY BODY DIRECTS GOVT TO SUBMIT DOCUMENTS

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 18

The House of Representatives, Education, Health and Information Technology Committee has directed the government to submit documents related to Mobile Device Management System (MDMS) and Telecommunication Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System (TERAMOCS).

A meeting of the committee held on Thursday directed the Ministry of Communications and Information Technology to submit the papers related to policy decisions, purchase process, payment and rationale of implementation concerning MDMS and TERAMOCS from the start.

It also decided to ask for the ministry-level investigation report on these topics and the court decisions related to the same and to take further decisions on the basis of consultations with experts.

The committee's decision comes after discussions it held with Minister for Communications and Information Technology Rekha Sharma, Ministry Secretary Ram Krishna Subedi, among other officials of the Ministry on Thursday.

In the meeting, Minister Sharma shared that the Ministry is studying the policy decisions made by the previous governments and the works carried out by the implementing bodies. She said the Ministry would cooperate in the investigations to be carried out by the authorised agency into the topic of any said irregularities in the implementation of these systems.

NEW EXECUTIVE BODY IN CONSTITUTIONAL LAWYERS' FORUM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan 18:

The 21st Annual General Meeting of the Constitutional Lawyers' Forum (CLaF) elected new executive committee under the leadership of advocate Om Prakash Aryal.

Similarly, the meeting unanimously elected advocate Liladhar Upadhyaya as general secretary, advocate Sharmila Shrestha as vice-chairperson and advocate Rosan Pokharel as treasurer.

Members of the new committee include senior advocate Dinesh Tripathi, advocate Ambar Raut, advocate Roshani Paudyal and advocate Pawan Jayasawal.

The Forum was formed in 2003 to fight against royal takeover and for restoration of democracy, rule of law and constitutional supremacy. This is an expert organisation engaged on constitutional dialogue, research and advocacy.

A five-member election committee was formed under the coordination of advocate Dr. Bhimarjun Acharya, the founding chairperson of the Forum. Members of the election committee include senior advocates Dr. Chandra Kanta Gyawali, Tika Ram Bhattarai, advocates Raju Prasad Chapagain and Lalit Basnet.

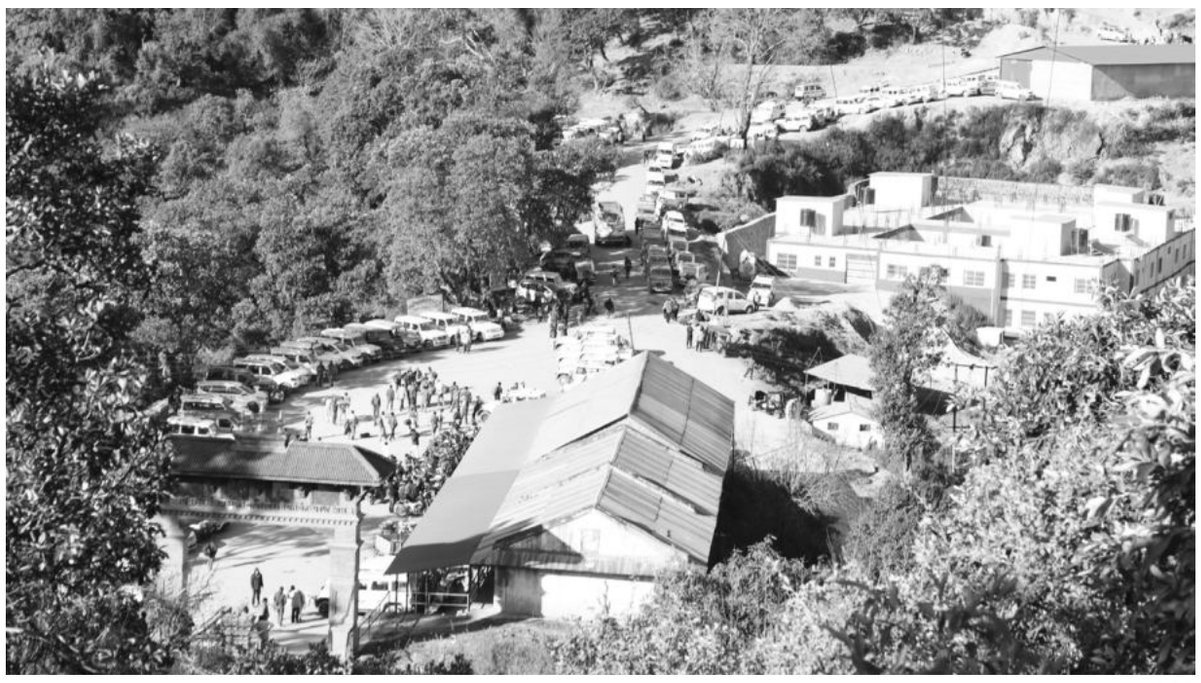


PHOTO: RSS

Dharampani Bazaar in Pyuthan district which acts as gateway and parking spot for the visitors to enter famous pilgrimage site Swargadwari.

Dadeldhura grappling with dearth of Kala-azar kits

BY PUSKAR BHANDARI
Dadeldhura, Jan. 18

The Epidemiology and Disease Control Division, Dadeldhura office is currently grappling with significant challenges in procuring the essential RK39 kits for testing Kala-azar, a tropical disease.

Gokarna Dahal, head of the Dadeldhura EDCD, speaking during the Sudhurpashchim Province Health Directorate's annual review programme, disclosed that despite initiating a tender for the procurement of these vital kits, the department has faced a notable setback as no applications have been received from potential suppliers. This has forced the department to turn to donor agencies to source the crucial testing kits, creating a pressing issue in the screening and treatment process for Kala-azar.

Kala-azar, also known as visceral leishmaniasis, is a potentially fatal parasitic disease transmitted by sandflies. Early detection and treatment are crucial for managing the disease effectively. The absence of testing kits poses a serious challenge in providing timely diagnosis and intervention, especially considering the government's ambitious target to eliminate Kala-azar by 2026.

Dahal underscored the severity of the situation, explaining that the lack of kits directly hampers the screening process, impeding efforts to address Kala-azar effectively. The disease has been particularly prevalent in the Sudurpashchim and Karnali Province, with the year 2023 alone reporting 191 cases in Nepal. Sudurpashchim Province alone accounted for 45 infections, emphasizing the urgency of addressing the situation.

In addition to the challenges with Kala-azar, Dahal raised concerns about the persistent risk of malaria in the region. The porous border with India heightens the risk, as malaria remains a significant health concern in the neighbouring country. Despite global efforts to eradicate malaria by 2025, challenges persist. In 2022, there were 600,000 malaria-related deaths worldwide, with a staggering 79 per cent occurring in India. Nepal, with its open border, faces an elevated risk of malaria transmission, necessitating robust examination and treatment arrangements at border checkpoints.

Health officials emphasized the need for coordinated efforts at various levels of government to effectively combat these infectious diseases.

Dr. Rudra Prasad Marasini, Director of the Epidemiology and Disease Control Division, stressed the urgency of establishing a separate health ministry in the province. The lack of coordination between the three government levels has hindered progress in addressing these health challenges. Marasini highlighted the importance of effective data provision and budget allocation for insect-borne disease eradication at the local level.

The annual review programme also sheds light on concerns about the quality and staffing of government labs. Despite the existence of government labs, their effectiveness has been hampered by a lack of skilled staff and the need for skill development training for existing technicians. These challenges underscore the need for ongoing investment in human resources and infrastructure to strengthen the health system's capacity to respond to infectious diseases.

As health officials in Dadeldhura grapple with challenges in procuring essential testing kits for Kala-azar and combatting malaria, there is a clear call for coordinated and urgent action. The effective allocation of resources, skill development training for healthcare professionals, and enhanced coordination between government levels are crucial elements in addressing these public health concerns and ensuring the well-being of the population.

Dharan team meets Deuba, Health Minister Basnet, seeks solution to BPKHS's problem

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dharan, Jan 18

Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet has said that the Executive Committee will convene a meeting to address the ongoing protest surfaced in the BP Koirala Institute of Health Sciences.

A delegation comprising representatives from five political parties in Dharan engaged in a substantial discussion with Health Minister Basnet regarding the institute's issues on Thursday.

During the discussion, it was decided that the executive committee would promptly formulate a proposal for submission to the board of directors. Simultaneously, plans were made to organise a special meeting of the board of directors to address the demand for the promotion of teaching staff.

Health Minister Basnet emphasised his commitment to addressing the concerns surrounding the BPKHS. He reported holding a joint meeting with Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Congress President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba, and Chief Secretary Baikunth Aryal. The Chief Secretary has been assigned the responsibility to conduct the necessary groundwork to meet the demands effectively.

Sujendra Tamang, President of Nepali Congress Dharan, disclosed that the delegation also met with NC president Deuba to discuss potential solutions to the challenges faced BPKHS.

The delegation included prominent members from various political parties, such as Congress central committee member and former minister Min Bishwakarma, Provincial Assembly member Bijay Rai, CPN United Socialist central member Jivan Rai, former mayor of Dharan, Tilak Rai, Congress municipal chairman Shyam Pokharel, CPN UML municipal president Harkajung Aveng, CPN Maoist central municipal chairman Manoj Bhattarai and Congress City Deputy chairman, Pravin Rai.

Makwanpur leaders draw PM's attention to Chitlang road

BY RAM MANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Jan. 18

People's representatives and political leaders from Makwanpur district have raised concerns over the construction of the Chitlang-Thankot road after a tragic accident on Saturday when a jeep overturned, killing five of six persons travelling on it.

Following the accident, they visited Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at the latter's office in Singha Durbar on Thursday and drew the Prime Minister's attention to the condition of the road.

During the meeting, they informed about the budget limitations for upgrading the Chitlang-Chandragiri-Thankot road and urged the Prime Minister to allocate around Rs. 80 million to Rs. 100 million for the road.

Member of the House of Representatives elected from Makwanpur Constituency-2 and CPN-UML Whip Mahesh Kumar Bartaula said that they requested the PM to advance the multi-year contract with the assurance of resources equal to Rs. 400 million.

Meanwhile, Rs. 20 million was allocated in the Fiscal Year 2023/024 for road upgrading. Stating that a detailed project of Rs. 1 billion had been prepared, the leaders from Makwanpur expressed dissatisfaction over the present budget allocation.

In response, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the road had historical significance and he had walked down the road, and committed to increasing budget allocation, informed Indrasarobar Rural Municipality Chairperson Dev Krishna Pudasaini.

He said that they had requested an additional budget of Rs. 100 million to Rs. 120 million and following it, the Prime Minister committed to providing Rs. 80 million within a month.

Constitution Assembly members Ram Narayan Bidari and Subash Chandra Thakuri, Nepali Congress leader Jayaram Lamichhane, Thaha Municipality Mayor Bishnu Bista, Thaha Municipality-9's Ward Chairman Raj Kumar Balami and CPN-UML Thaha Municipal Committee Secretary Ram Krishna Basnet were present in the meeting.

Lawmaker Bartaula stressed the need to exert pressure on the government for the upliftment of the Chitlang-Thankot road.

Five people were killed when a private car, Ford, with a registration number (Bagmati Pradesh, 01-023 Cha 6985), met with an accident at Seto Pahara of Chitlang-Thankot Road section on Saturday afternoon.

Madhes gives high priority to infrastructure projects

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 18

The government of Madhes Province prioritised physical infrastructure in the last year.

According to the figures released by the province's Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development, the province has been building five kilometres of paved road in each of its 64 provincial assembly constituencies.

Over the past year, the provincial government has blacktopped 35 kilometres of road and concretised 124 kilometres more. Similarly, it has gravelled 300 kilometres of road, constructed 41 kilometres of drains, built 233 culverts and upgraded 37 kilometres of unpaved roads. Madhes has also implemented the provincial road network masterplan.

Similarly, the province has built eight bridges and is building 28 more. Three suspension bridges are also under construction as part of the suspension bridge programme.

The provincial government has also allocated budget for the construction of the 312-kilometre Mashes Martyr's Highway from Parsa to Saptari.

Furthermore, 6,693 houses have been built under the public housing programme and 456 houses have been constructed under the Mahendra Narayan Nidhi housing programme.

The municipalities located at the headquarters of all eight districts of the province have coordinated

> According to the figures released by the province's Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development, the province has been building five kilometres of paved road in each of its 64 provincial assembly constituencies.

and begun work on building eight labour resting places. Land has been acquired and the detailed project report has been prepared to construct a Transport Management Office (TMO) in Birgunj while land is being acquired to establish TMOs at Janakpurdham, Bardibas, Rajbiraj and Gaur.

The released data also shows that irrigation facility has been extended to 2,540 hectares of land through surface, underground and cluster irrigation projects.

The province has also completed 41 drinking water projects, benefitting 20,000 households. It has built 54 public toilets to promote hygiene and has planned to make the Ram Janaki Stadium an international-standard sports ground to promote sports.

According to Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development Krishna Prasad Yadav, the province has focused on infrastructure to bring about prosperity.

KMC's cyber security training...

as well as young students, job seekers and returnee migrants who are desperate to equip themselves with better cyber security skills. These skills include identifying spam emails, malware, spyware and misinformation as well as the knowledge of ethical hacking, said Acharya.

"Every job has become digital and needs to be done through the application of information and cyber technology. Adopting these digital initiatives needs better security and skilled workers," he said while adding that individuals are highly vulnerable to cybercrimes and internet-based risks.

Likewise, Jha said that the training would help youth stay in the country while working in a company anywhere across the globe.

The total cost of the cyber security training project is estimated at Rs. 50 million. Prince Khetan, CEO and Co-Founder of Gap Technologies, said that the training could be a long-term project and expected to raise awareness as well as the skills about cyber security.

This project is a part of the KMC's ambitious pride project on employment which aims at training at least 15,000 people in 34 thematic areas in the next three years as envisioned by its Mayor Balendra Shah, and creating jobs for 5,000 people in a year.

Other areas of training that have been launched are software development, beautician, digital marketing and professional accounting. Other disciplines will be added according to the demand.

"We want to create solutions for both the job providers and job seekers. It will supply full-time and part-time workforce to the companies through the 'Labour Bank'," said Jha.

The government, national and international non-government agencies, private sector companies and other organisations will be provided access to the labour bank where they can choose the human resources that fit into their job demand.

Residents of the KMC or its taxpayers, and Nepali citizens having rental accommodations in Kathmandu Metropolis are the primary target of the training while other Nepalis are considered as the secondary target.

Nepal, UN reach agreement on...

the Cooperation Framework is the centrepiece for the implementation of the UN Development System reform at the country level. It articulates how the UN is supporting the people and Government of Nepal in achieving its development goals.

The meeting was attended by government representatives and UN Country Team members.

Policy reform...

approved and is being implemented.

The Security Printing Press Bill and the Public Service Broadcasting Bill are under discussion in the committee of the Federal Parliament, while the draft of the Nepal Media Council Bill has been sent to the Ministry of Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs for endorsement with the approval from the Ministry of Finance. The draft of the Mass Media Bill and the draft of the Social Network (Management and Regulation) Bill have been prepared and sent to the Ministry of Finance for approval, she informed.

A proposal has been submitted to the Council of Ministers to review the salary of working journalists, which has not been increased for the past five years, she said. The government is determined and committed to making all government-owned media more inclusive. Radio Nepal, Nepal Television and Gorkhapatra Daily are increasing the number of multi-lingual speakers, while news service in mother tongue has started from RSS, she said.

Also, the Minister has said that the Ministry will launch 'smart school programme' for quality education in some secondary level public schools.

Minister Sharma said that 19 districts, including Jajarkot and Rukum West, which were affected by the earthquake, have been declared as model districts for the improvement of quality and access of fiber-to-home service (FTTH).

Biden will promote internet access in North Carolina

AP
Washington, Jan. 18

President Joe Biden is going to North Carolina on Thursday to highlight $82 million in new investments that would connect 16,000 households and businesses to high-speed internet.

Biden's reelection campaign has made winning North Carolina and its 16 electoral votes one of its top priorities in this year's presidential election. The Democrat narrowly lost the state in 2020 by 1.34 percentage points to then-President Donald Trump, the current Republican front-runner in what will likely be a political rematch in 2024.

The Democratic president plans to use his stop in the state capital of Raleigh to stress that his administration is connecting poorer communities and businesses to the digital economy.

Polling shows that the economy has been a weakness for Biden, a reflection of inflation hitting a four-decade high in June 2022. Easing inflation rates since then have yet to pull Biden's approval ratings back to their levels at the start of his presidency.

One way the administration says it has lowered costs for families is by providing discounted internet service to



> The Democratic president plans to use his stop in the state capital of Raleigh to stress that his administration is connecting poorer communities and businesses to the digital economy.

880,000 households in North Carolina.

The administration is committing a total of $3 billion to build out and fund internet connections in North Carolina. Estimates from the administration are that an additional 300,000 of the state's residents will be able to access the internet by the end of 2026.

RUSSIAN BORDER CITY CANCELS ORTHODOX EPIPHANY EVENTS

AP
Belgorod, Jan. 18

A Russian city near the Ukrainian border canceled its traditional Orthodox Epiphany festivities on Friday due to the threat of attacks as Kyiv's forces pursue a new strategy with the war approaching its two-year milestone.

The city of Belgorod has scrapped events in which the faithful plunge into ponds and pools through holes in the ice on the feast of Epiphany every Jan. 19, the state news agency Tass reported, citing the regional emergencies ministry. The annual celebrations are widespread in Russia.

Cross-border attacks have become increasingly frequent in recent weeks in Belgorod, the largest Russian city near the border with about 340,000 people, and can be reached by relatively simple and movable weapons such as multiple rocket launchers. It is about 100 kilometers (60 miles) north of Kharkiv, Ukraine's second-largest city.

Rabi Mishra's cartoons on display



PHOTO: TRN

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Popular cartoonist Rabi Mishra's 1st solo cartoon exhibition, titled 'Depiction,' has kicked off at Umoja Cafe in NB Centre, Naya Baneshwor, Kathmandu, starting from Thursday.

The 10-day exhibition, running until January 28, showcases Mishra's first-ever solo collection, featuring around 35 cartoons that have been previously published in various newspapers and magazines over his illustrious career of 17 years.

Mishra, also the general secretary of the Cartoonist Club of Nepal, expressed his belief that cartoons go beyond mere images, they serve as a powerful medium for expressing views, emotions and humor.

"Cartoons are a great means for me to communicate with society," Mishra remarked, emphasising the significance of satire in his work.

The exhibition highlights Mishra's unique perspective on current events, societal scenes, characters, trends, and ideas through the lens of satire.

Despite engaging in other forms of art, Mishra proudly identifies himself as a cartoonist.

His cartoons challenge and provide commentary on those in positions of power, reflecting his commitment to addressing and disagreeing with prevailing events and ideas in society.

Viewers have the opportunity to watch cartoons that satirise politicians, societal issues and those in power.

Mishara said that he chose to showcase his cartoon exhibition in the open spaces of a mall rather than art galleries.

The aim was to generate awareness among the general audience about the art of cartoons and its significance in society, he added.

Magar Museum being built in Devchuli Municipality

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 18



A building has been constructed at Devchuli Municiplaity-10 of East Nawalparsi to establish a Magar Museum.

The museum constructed at Prithvi Nagar of Devchuli-10 will be used to preserve and promote art, artefacts, costumes and cultures of the Magar community as the Magar community is losing its cultural identity because of modernism.

Their original arts, culture, tradition and costumes are on the verge of extinction.

Bhuwan Singh Ale, the President of the Magar Museum, said, "The museum established in Devchuli- 10 will help future generations to feel proud of their cultural identity and connect with their roots"

The clothes, utensils, musical instruments and livelihood-related materials used by the Magar community will be displayed in the museum, said Ale.

The museum was constructed at the cost of Rs. 2.2 million. Devchuli Municipality has provided Rs. 1 million under the city-level ward promotion programme and Rs. 5, 00,000 was provided by ward no. 10, said Repti Kumar Gharti, ward chairperson of ward no.10.

Ale further stressed that the state should invest in the development and promotion of the Magar Museum as it would aid internal tourism.

Gayan Bahadur Rana, the Secretary of the Museum, said, "Art and artifacts depicting the Magar civilization were collected for the museum."

Preparations are underway to inaugurate the museum on 27 February.

'MASINYA'TO BE STAGED AT MANDALA THEATRE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

The play 'Masinya' is scheduled to take place at Mandala Theatre in Thapagaon, Kathman from January 25 to February 11. Written by Rabat Syangtang and Laxmi Rumba, the play is directed and conceptualised by Buddhi Tamang and Sonam Lama.

Director Buddhi informed that the play delves into the pain and struggles endured by the Tamang caste over centuries, primarily addressing community issues. He added that the play not only narrates the tragic tale of the Tamang people but also portrays the rhythm, beauty, culture, and environment of Tamang life.

Sonam, another director, said that the play contributes to a deeper understanding of the Tamang community through this dramatic presentation. Currently, rehearsals are taking place at the Nepal Tamang Ghedung hall in Bauddha, Chuchchepati. Artists including Sunil Tamang, Rabin Dong and Ramila Moktan are preparing to bring the play to life.

Ariana Grande announces new album

AP
New York, Jan. 18

Thank you, next: Ariana Grande announced on Wednesday that her new album, titled "eternal sunshine," will be released on March 8.

Last Friday, Grande released her first single from "eternal sunshine," a house-informed pop kiss-off to the haters, "yes, and?"

News of the album first broke Dec. 27, when the two-time Grammy award winner teased the future full-length album on her Instagram page. It will be her seventh studio album and first since 2020's "Positions."

"See you next year," she wrote in the caption of the Instagram post, which included images in a studio and in front of a mixing board, and a video where someone off screen tells her it is "almost the last day of this album." Grande responds, "I'm so tired," and laughs. "But so happy and grateful. I also feel like I weigh 3,000 tons."

On her Instagram story, she shared a screenshot captured from FaceTime with the text: "The two moods of the album."

She also shared posts from fans who received packages from her in the mail containing red lipstick from her R.E.M. Beauty line and a note that also read, "See you next year."

The album announcement arrived a few weeks after news broke that Ariana Grande signed to Good World Management firm, following her split with long-term manager Scooter Braun.

The new album will also be her first since her marriage and subsequent separation from real estate agent Dalton Gomez.

Jason Momoa travels outside comfort zone in docuseries 'On the Roam

REUTERS
Los Angeles, Jan. 18



Jason Momoa is excited to shed his acting persona and show audiences the real him in his new docuseries "On the Roam."

"You get to see me not hiding behind the character trying to be, you know, king of this or warlord of that, this cool guy and that weird guy. It's just 100% me. So scary," Momoa said in an interview.

The MAX series, produced by the Discovery Channel, follows the "Aquaman" star across the country meeting inspiring experts in what they love.

From musicians to craftspeople, Momoa finds a connection with people from various walks of life in the series whose first two episodes premiere on Jan. 18.

"The cool thing is even though we travel around the world, it's like you get the intimate look of going into someone's world, all these different beautiful worlds," he said. Momoa makes it a point to soak up the local culture anyway wherever he travels to shoot a movie or have fun.

Every person and place he visited for the docuseries offered something special and authentic, the "Game of Thrones" actor said. "You can always find one really extremely interesting thing or person, and just sit and listen."

Momoa is also the executive producer of "On The Roam" along with Brian Andrew Mendoza, who produced "Braven," which starred Momoa in 2018. While apprehensive about showing a more personal side of himself, he is optimistic that people will appreciate the stories.

"You know, it's scary because it's everything that I love and, it's always like, is it good? Is it gonna get ratings? Is this good? Is it not?" Momoa said. "And it's just all my love and hard work going into it, and I hope people love it."

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ARIES: Knowing who to trust can be tricky at this time. You might be faced with two different stories that both sound pretty good but conflict with each other, and you're not sure which one more closely resembles reality.

TAURUS: Your perspective might be skewed, landing you in hot water. You potentially have a lot of emotions tied up in a situation that's going awry, and because of your emotions.

GEMINI: An authority figure in your life might clash with a peer. You could feel caught in the middle of two people who both have a strong influence on your life, perhaps your boss and a coworker.

CANCER: Bad habits may be blocking your path forward. Your recent life could feel rather unfocused as you let the currents of time carry you where they will. Watch out -- this might be about to take you over a waterfall.

LEO: You may need to get your hands dirty at any moment. A moment when you once avoided some hard work may turn into a glaring problem that needs immediate attention.

VIRGO: Travel might be calling your name. You may feel that it's too sudden or too chaotic to plan or attempt travel at this time, but getting out of your comfort zone in small ways could be enough to fulfill this need for change.

LIBRA: You might be collaborating with someone you've never worked alongside before. It may be that you've wanted to work with this person for a while, or they could simply be much more experienced than you.

SCORPIO: Someone else can take the reins. You could sometimes feel like you have to do everything yourself, unwilling to let others help -- even when you need it. This might be wearing you down!

SAGITTARIUS: Bending the truth is probably very tempting. It may be hard to be honest today, because speaking truthfully might cast you in a negative light or be painful to the person hearing the truth.

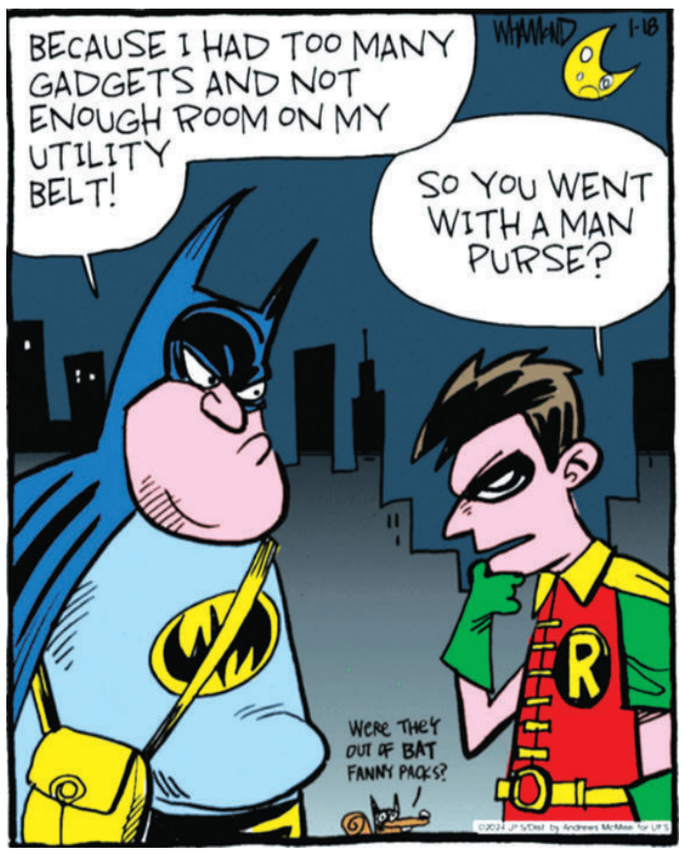
CAPRICORN: You're creating your own avenue. You may have had a hobby that you want to turn into a side hustle, even if there isn't quite a niche for it yet. This is where you get to find out how you operate in uncertainty.

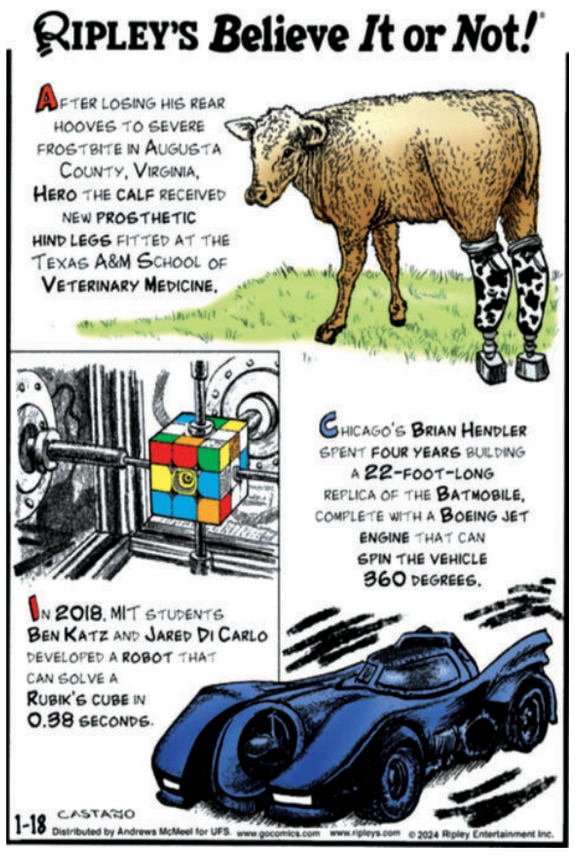
AQUARIUS: Family members, found or biological, have wisdom to offer. They may provide their knowledge by telling you about past experiences that they or other relatives went through.

PISCES: What you want matters, Pisces! You may have stayed quiet about your hopes and dreams as of late, preferring to work on them in silence to see how close you can get to the goals that you have for yourself.

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Sudur Pashchim remains unbeaten, Madhes, Army grab their 2nd win

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

Sudur Pashchim Province has won its third consecutive match in the ongoing PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament after defeating Gandaki Province at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground on Thursday.

Sudur Pashchim won the match by 108 runs. At the end of Day 6, Sudur Pashchim stands at the top of the league table with six points in three matches. Nepal Police Club, the only other unbeaten team in the season so far, is in the second position with four points in two matches.

Electing to field first, Gandaki bowled out Sudur Pashchim at 201 runs with the final wicket of Naren Saud in the final bowl of the 50th over. While Bipin Khatri and Ankit Neupane took three wickets each, Kamal Pariyar and Amrit Gurung claimed two each for Gandaki.

Sudur Pashchim's top order failed to score sufficiently. After the wicket of captain Raju Rijal in 22.2 overs, Sudur Pashchim was left at 68 in the loss of five wickets. Milan Bohora followed Rijal in the 26th over leaving the team at 72-6.

It was thanks to Kiran Thagunna and Narayan Joshi that Sudur Pashchim was able to cross the 200-run-mark. While Thagunna got to a half-century, Joshi fell short of four runs.

While the team failed to put up a satisfactory target, it did not fail with the ball. Sher Malla's five-wicket haul helped Sudur Pashchim bowl out Gandaki at 93 runs in the 31st over. Gajendra Bohora took two wickets and Naren Saud, Milan Bohora and Bhoj Raj Bhatta bagged one each for Sudur Pashchim.

Only two batsmen scored in two digits for Gandaki in the chase. Aswani Rana faced 67 balls to score 25 while Kamal Pariyar stood his ground until the 49th ball and departed at 22 runs. In the 93 runs of Gandaki, 25 came from extras.



PHOTO: CAN
Rupesh Singh of Madhes raises his bat after a half-century against Nepal APF Club on Thursday.

On the other hand, Tribhuwan Army Club was able to bounce back on Thursday after a devastating defeat against Bagmati on Wednesday. Fielding first, Bagmati bowled out Army at 97 runs.

Nevertheless, Army showed that its bowling line-up was not a joke. Bagmati lost seven wickets to chase the low target of 98 in the 23rd over. And, on Thursday, electing to field first, Army's bowlers bowled out Koshi Province at 88 runs in the Mulpani International Cricket Ground.

Shahab Alam's six-wicket haul was the best figure for Army as he bowled for only 6.4 overs. Kushal Malla took two wickets and Sompal Kami and Bibek Yadav took one each.

Firdosh Ansari opened the match for Koshi with captain Ankit Subedi. However, Ansari was caught after hitting a four in the ball of Kami. Subedi stayed until the 13th over and departed at 41 runs after getting caught behind. None of the other batsmen scored in two digits for Koshi. Army's bowlers gave 19 runs in extras.

Meanwhile, Army lost only one wicket to chase the target in only 10 overs. Sujan Thapaliya took the only wicket for Koshi as Army's opener Imran Sheikh was struck leg before after scoring 32 runs off 25 balls. Another opener Santosh Karki remained not out at 32 runs off 27 balls with Kushal Malla.

Hitting six in 9.5 overs in the bowl of Saujan Ghimire, Malla won the match for Army as the team reached 92. He scored 22 runs in only seven balls.

In the third match of the day at TU International Cricket Ground, Madhes emerged victorious against Nepal Armed Police Force (APF) Club.

Having given to bat first by Madhes, APF's top order played a quality inning. While opener Prajwal Shahi was caught for a duck, Aasif Sheikh and captain Rohit Paudel scored individual half-centuries in a partnership of 132 runs. Sheikh and Paudel departed after scoring 59 and 58 respectively.

After the wickets of two quality batsmen, APF had to wait for Amar Routela, who came in at 8. Routela fell only one run short of his half-century as the batting inning came to an end with the completion of the 50th over. Routela's inning helped APF paste a target of 247 runs in the loss of nine wickets.

Rupesh Singh and Pradip Paswan took three wickets each for Madhes.

With the bat, Madhes only lost five wickets as it chased the target with two overs remaining. There were three half-centuries for Madhes in the win. Pawan Sarraf scored 64 runs in 66 balls, Niraj Yadav scored 52 in 70 and Rupesh Singh hit 72 at a strike rate of 100.

Five athletes nominated for Peoples' Choice at NSJF-Pulsar Sports Award

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18

The Nepal Sports Journalists Forum (NSJF) made public the five athletes for the 'People's Choice' in the 20th edition of the NSJF-Pulsar Sports Award.

Organising a press meet at the capital on Wednesday, the organisers informed that sports enthusiasts will be voting for footballer Ananta Tamang, karate player Biplov Lal Shrestha, volleyball player Niruta Thagunna, table tennis player Sikka Suwal Shrestha and bodybuilder Rajani Shrestha for the 'Peoples' Choice Award'.

Athletes selected from 27 games will be feted in a total of nine categories, including the Peoples' Choice, at the NSJF-Pulsar Sports Award. The players will be adjudged based on their performances during mid-April 2022 to mid-April 2023.

Stakeholders, including the general public, will be allowed to vote in five categories, including the Peoples' Choice category, while the winners for other categories will be decided by a jury of experts. Nominations for the other four categories is said to be made public soon.

NSJF has coordinated with Hansaraj Hulaschand and Company for the sports award. While the organisers had informed of organising the ceremony on January 26, it has been rescheduled for February 11.

According to the organisers, Peoples' Choice winner will be decided on the vote counts from eSewa, social media (NSJF Pulsar Sports Award and Pulsar Nepal's Facebook pages), chief coaches of 27 games and NSJF members.

Votes from eSewa will share a value of 50 per cent while those from social media are valued 25 per cent. Likewise, the votes from coaches and NSJF members will have a value of 12.5 per cent each while selecting the winner of the 'Peoples' Choice Award'.

Voting will be open until a day earlier of the award ceremony.

BAJAJ Pulsar Sports Award 2079

Ananta Tamang, Biplov Lal Shrestha, Niruta Thagunna, Sikka Suwal Shrestha and Rajani Shrestha have been nominated for 'People's Choice Award'.

Five nominated athletes

Footballer Ananta Tamang has led different teams to win several domestic leagues. Church Boys United won its maiden A Division league title while debuting in the league under the captainship of Tamang. He also led his team Lalitpur City FC to clinch NSL Season 2 trophy recently. Tamang has also shown his quality in almost every game he has played wearing the national jersey.

Karateka Biplov Lal Shrestha won two bouts in the 19th Asian Games and was able to win a silver medal at the World Shitoryu Karatedo International Championships held in Jakarta, Indonesia. Volleyball player Niruta Thagunna was in the Nepal squad that won the bronze medal at the CAVA Women's Challenge Cup. She was also the best player in the Keshav Lal Shrestha Memorial National Women's Volleyball Tournament.

Table tennis player Sikka Suwal Shrestha is a national champion in doubles. She also won the 2023 Stag Global Champions League.

Bodybuilder Rajani Shrestha was the gold medalist in the category of above 55kg at the 55th Asian Body Building Championship held in Nepal. She was able to show that body building was not only for men by proving herself in the international stage.

KHADKA PROMOTED TO 2ND CLASS INTERNATIONAL REFEREE IN POOMSAE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 18



Ashok Khadka, an international 3rd class taekwondo referee from Nepal has been promoted to the 2nd class International Refree in the Poomsae category by the World Taekwondo (WT), an international federation governing the sport of taekwondo.

The WT provided the promotion certificate to Khadka on Thursday. The promotion was a result of the points he gathered after participating in taekwondo competitions and refresher courses. A referee requires at least eight points to get promoted to the 2nd class from the 3rd. "It took around five years to get promoted to the 2nd class," Khadka shared.

Khadka took part in 10 Poomsae competitions and a refresher course in a span of around five years. The competitions he participated in as a referee include World Taekwondo Poomsae Championship and Kimunyong Cup in South Korea, Australian Open, President Cup, Oceania Open Poomsae Championship, Bulgaria Open, Chuncheon Korea Open and Mexico Open among others. He reached South Korea in 2022 to take part in the 45th International Poomsae Refresher Course. Khadka is an international-level referee in three categories – Kyorugi Poomsae, Poomsae and Para – of taekwondo.

Khadka was also honoured as the best referee under the National Sports Talent Honour by the Ministry of Youths and Sports two years ago.

Forest, Everton into FA Cup 4th round

AFP
London, Jan. 18

Forest survived a scare to beat third-tier Blackpool 3-2 after extra-time, while Everton were 1-0 winners against Crystal Palace in another of the night's third-round replays.

It was a welcome tonic for Forest and Everton, who were both referred to an independent commission by the Premier League on Monday after admitting to breaches of financial rules.

Blackpool gave Forest a huge scare before Nuno Espirito Santo's side finally advanced to the last 32.

Andrew Omobamidele put Forest in front with a close-range volley in the 16th minute after Nicolas Dominguez's corner was flicked on by Ryan Yates. Danilo doubled Forest's advantage just 53 seconds after the interval.

Blackpool keeper Daniel Grimshaw made a hash of clearing Albie Morgan's wayward backpass and Danilo swooped in with a close-range finish.

Morgan made amends for his role in that debacle when he lashed into the top corner from 18 yards in the 61st minute.

With Forest suddenly creaking, Kyle Joseph equalised in the 78th minute with a header from Andy Lyons' cross.

But New Zealand striker Chris Wood settled Forest's nerves in the 110th minute, turning in the winner from Yates's cross.

Forest will travel to second-tier Bristol City, who enjoyed a shock victory against West Ham on Tuesday.

Everton kept their focus amid the FA intervention as they saw off Palace at Goodison Park.

Their first win in all competitions since December 16 earned a home game against Luton in the fourth round.

Andre Gomes smashed a 20-yard free-kick past Johnstone to give Everton the lead in the 42nd minute.

It was Everton's first goal since December 27 after three scoreless outings.

Norwich clinched a fourth-round trip to Liverpool as the Championship side survived a scare to win 3-1 at Bristol Rovers.

Rovers, 11th in League One, took a surprise lead in the replay through Luke McCormick's low drive from the edge of the area in the 20th minute. But Gabriel Sara bagged Norwich's equaliser in the 53rd minute, Adam Idah converted a penalty six minutes and Kenny McLean's 87th-minute rocket put the result beyond doubt.

Facing Liverpool means a reunion between Liverpool manager Jurgen Klopp and his friend David Wagner, the German boss of Norwich.



Australia set to win 1st test against West Indies early

AP
Adelaide, Jan. 18

Australia was set to force an early end to the first cricket test against West Indies after taking six second-innings wickets late on the second day at the Adelaide Oval on Thursday.

The Caribbean side was 73-6 in its second innings and still trails Australia by 22 runs going into Day 3 on Friday. Travis Head earlier scored 119 from 134 balls to help put Australia in a strong position with 283 runs and a first-innings lead of 95 runs. Head mixed some edgy near-misses with audacious stroke-play, smacking a dozen fours and three sixes.

Shamar Joseph took his third wicket on his debut for West Indies and Australia went to lunch Thursday at 144-5 and trailed the Caribbean side by 44 runs.

The 24-year-old Joseph took the prized wicket of new Australian opener Steve Smith with his first ball in test cricket on the opening day Wednesday at the Adelaide Oval. Joseph added the wicket of Marnus Labuschagne before stumps Wednesday, when Australia was 59-2. On Thursday, Joseph had new No. 4 batter Cameron Green out for 14.

Pace bowler Joseph, who made 36 batting at No. 11 — the second-highest score in the visitor's innings — had eventual figures of 5-94. Australia captain Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood took four wickets each as Australia restricted West Indies to 188 and made good use of the Adelaide Oval pitch after winning the toss and bowling first.

West Indies, which hasn't won a test match Down Under since February 1997, has brought only five players who appeared in the two tests against Australia in 2022-23 and added seven uncapped players to the touring squad.

The second and final test in the series, a day-night match at the Gabba in Brisbane, begins Jan. 25.

PHOTO: JAMES ELSBY VIA AP
Australia's Travis Head celebrates catching out West Indies' Kraigg Brathwaite on the second day of their cricket test match in Adelaide, Australia, Thursday.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:33 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 17 - 19°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.8	6.2	0.0
Dipayal	19.5	4.7	0.0
Dhangadi	16.7	10.0	0.0
Birendranagar	21.2	5.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	17.0	10.8	0.0
Jumla	21.0	-3.9	0.0
Ghorahi	22.6	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	21.2	7.3	0.0
Bhairahawa	16.0	7.0	0.0
Simara	15.5	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.8	4.6	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.7	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	19.2	5.2	0.0
Dhankuta	23.7	8.0	0.0
Biratnagar	15.6	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	15.0	0.0	0.0*
Dharan	18.5	8.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.9	5.7	0.0*
Janakpur	21.0	12.4	0.0*
Jiri	17.9	0.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 19, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.70	Rs. 133.30
Euro	1	Rs. 144.52	Rs. 145.17
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.42	Rs. 169.18
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.37	Rs. 154.07
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.18	Rs. 87.58
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.41	Rs. 98.86
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.79	Rs. 99.24
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.98	Rs. 9.02
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.45	Rs. 18.53
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.73	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.13	Rs. 28.25
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.92	Rs. 9.96
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.76
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.38	Rs. 19.46
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.97	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.21	Rs. 433.16
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.01	Rs. 353.60

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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Barking Deer: Gentle Creature Of The Wild



Rajesh Dhungana

> Despite their adaptability, the species faces severe threats in Nepal, primarily from poaching and habitat loss, as noted in various studies.



The barking deer, scientifically known as Muntiacus muntjak, is an attractive inhabitant of the dense tropical and subtropical forests of Nepal. Ratuwa Mriga is a common Nepali term for this animal. Recognised for its shyness, this small, smooth, and beautiful creature has gained its moniker due to its ability to emit continuous barking sounds for up to an hour as an alarm in the face of danger. The term "barking deer" encompasses various species within the Muntiacini tribe of the Cervidae family, known for their distinctive noise.

These adorable creatures play a vital role in the ecosystems and are primarily solitary and crepuscular, displaying peak activity during dawn and dusk. Distributed across national parks, community forests, and hilly regions in Nepal, barking deer's prime habitat occupies a significant portion of the country, as indicated by the Department of Forest Research and Survey (2015). Barking deer, with small unbranched antlers of up to 15 cm make territorial fights using their horns and canines for struggle. Their coat is short, soft and darkens from brown to yellow with its white dorsum. Males are more substantial than females, and they have an inch-long top which curls outside displaying aggressions. They have a lifespan of 20-30 years. They defend themselves from predators but viciously claim their territory.

Despite a declining population, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) has categorised the barking deer as "least concerned." This species extends its habitat beyond Nepal, being found in southern Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka, Pakistan, Cambodia, Vietnam, the Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, the Riau Islands, Belitung, Java, Wali, and Borneo. It represents one of eleven Muntjack species across Asia, part of the well-known genus Muntiacus, which includes the Indian muntjac, common muntjac, Formosan muntjac, Chinese muntjac, and others.

Taxonomic studies by Colin Groves and Peter Grubb in the 1990s suggested the existence of distinct species within the red muntjacs. In 2011, further taxonomic research identified three different species in India, including Muntiacus vaginalis in some regions of northeast India, Nepal, and Myanmar. This research also differentiated the red Muntjacs of north-west and central India (Muntiacus aureus) and the red Muntjacs of the Western Ghats and Sri Lanka (Muntiacus malabaricus) as three distinct species, refining the understanding of the barking deer's taxonomy and distribution.



Habitat and breeding

The barking deer lives in tropics and sub-tropical areas such as deciduous forests, grasslands, savannas, and shrubs, which are also known to survive up the mountains at an altitude of 300 metres above sea level. They prefer to live in thick forests, and their small size combined with a secretive lifestyle contributes effectively to the avoidance of predators. With a good sense of hearing, such deer produce alarm calls upon the detection of perils to enable group flight. They feed on grass, fruits, shoots, and seeds that may occur in the vicinity of forest fringes. Of particular interest are its scavenging tendencies and bark-calls in response to predators. Males create a territory that is discriminated against with scent markers, where territorial fights occur during mating. They have short horns and large canine teeth as their defensive weaponry. If they cannot secure a territory, weaker males fall prey to predators like tigers and leopards. However, during the rut, these boundaries become foggy as males search for receptive females, emphasising the dynamics of barking deer behaviour in relation to environmental change.

The barking deer is polygamous, exhibiting specific breeding seasons varying by region. Breeding occurs year-round, with peak activity marked by intensified vocalisations from males attracting females. Females reach sexual maturity in their first to second years, cycling every 14 to 21 days with a 2-day estrus. A 6 to 7 month gestation results in single or occasional twin births. Cubs establish territories after 6 months, distinguishing barking deer from other ungulates by lacking a specific breeding season.

Threats

Barking deer face numerous threats, with primary concern being hunting for their meat and skin, especially on the fringes of agricultural zones where they are perceived as nuisance for causing vegetation damage and stripping tree bark. Their meat's popularity among predatory animals like tigers and leopards further exposes them to hunting pressure. Additionally, human-induced habitat loss and fragmentation contribute to the decline of their once-abundant population. In the central mountainous region of Nepal, barking deer constitute a significant portion of leopard prey, emphasising the impact of these threats on the species.

As per Asish Neupane, Conservation and Information Officer of Bardia National Park, the barking deer, the most widely distributed deer species in Nepal, spans from the Terai to hilly regions. Recognised as the smallest deer in Bardia and Chitwan National Parks, their distinct vocalisation, akin to a dog's bark, serves as a warning signal against predators.

Despite their adaptability, the species faces severe threats in Nepal, primarily from poaching and habitat loss, as noted in various studies. Legal measures are in place to deter such activities, with Section 26 of the National Parks and Wildlife Protection Act, 2029, imposing fines ranging from 20,000 to 50,000 rupees or imprisonment from 6 months to 1 year for unauthorised hunting and harm to wild animals within designated conservation areas.

(The author is a wildlife photographer. The photos used in this article are by the author himself.)

Gender-Inclusive Energy Sector



Sanju Adhikari



Nepal is one of the richest countries in terms of water resources, with over 6,000 rivers and rivulets running across the country. The country's advantageous feature lies in its steep topography, which provides ample opportunities for hydropower generation. Out of the total potential generation capacity of approximately 83,000 megawatts, about 42,000 megawatts are deemed economically viable. Hydropower plays a predominant role in Nepal's electricity system and economy too. The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA), a state-owned company, had sole authority for the production, transmission, and distribution of electricity in Nepal before 1912. After the introduction of the Electricity Act 1992 and the Hydropower Policy 2001, the hydropower licences were distributed, and power purchase agreements were signed with private hydropower investors. After the entrance of the private sector into hydropower development, power generation activities significantly increased. As per the study undertaken by the World Bank in 2021, about 90 per cent of the total population has access to electricity in Nepal. This also indicates the space for achievement in making electricity accessible to everyone. The country has prioritised energy production as one of the most powerful sources of income-exporting power in neighbouring countries.

The total population of Nepal on Census Day (November 25, 2021) was 29,164,578. Of this, the male population was 14,253,551 (48.87 per cent) and that of females, 14,911,027 (51.13 per cent). The sex ratio was 95.59 males per 100 females. According to the detailed census report, the literacy rate of the population aged five years and older is 76.3 per cent: the male literacy rate was 83.6 per cent and female literacy was 69.4 per cent. Women's involvement in economic opportunities is largely limited within domestic affairs, which are not accounted for in the gross domestic product calculation of a nation. The active participation of women in project design and its development process has been a critical issue. Women's everyday lives are associated with the protection and use of natural resources. Since a large population of men has foreign employment opportunities, women are carrying the responsibilities of home, elders, children, and family occupations like farming, poultry, etc. Women's participation and their engagement in hydropower projects are critical components for their successful completion.

The Hydropower Environment Assessment Manual 2018 ensures the acquisition of gender disintegration data during the Environment Impact Assessment (EIA). It focuses on including gender-related impacts such as employment, marginalisation, SES/SH, impacts due to the influx of migrant workers, crime, trafficking, and loss of livelihood opportunities. The Environment Protection Act 2076 and its Regulation 2077 have provisioned for public hearings and notification in national newspapers in the process of impact assessment. However, it is silent about inclusive participation and the mandatory presence of women's participation in these consultations. In the case of projects financed by international financing institutions (IFIs), due to their mandatory policy for inclusive consultation, a certain number of developers are trying to reach the minimum figure required. Private developers and the NEA significantly ignore the participation of women and vulnerable communities in the promoted project.

The expansion of the electricity supply will result in considerable positive changes in the communities, both male and female. It can bring positive economic changes through better job opportunities, effective health services, and access to education. During hydropower infrastructure development, women can benefit from getting direct employment opportunities and operating small businesses. Job opportunities are created following the construction phase. This will drive positive changes in women and their everyday lives. However, women are deprived of the advantages of power generation, transmission, and distribution projects. The existing socio-cultural dynamics of communities and power relations in households have hindered women from participating actively in the planning and development of power generation projects.

Literacy is considered a major constraint that hinders women from participating in public meetings. Men are two steps ahead of women because they receive more exposure and opportunities in education and participation. Difficult topography is one of the key factors that creates obstacles for women in participating in consultations and decision-making. Due to the difficult topography, there is a tendency to organise consultation meetings in market centres and accessible locations. In the case of hydropower projects, such centres are generally far from project-affected communities. Public hearings and consultation meetings are generally conducted in market centres and other convenient locations. This has been a limitation for women and the least privileged to travel and attend such programmes.

Existing Social norms, household responsibilities, mobility, and social acceptances are considered other factors creating hindrances to women's participation in public meetings. Women's participation in community meetings is discouraged. Generally, men are considered household heads, and land titles are registered in their names. By virtue of being the household head, man is considered to be a powerful person in decision-making. Patriarchal social structure and household leadership have placed man as the supreme human in the family. So, he is free to make family decisions on his own for the disposal of family properties and resettlement compensations. Men come forward to participate in extra-household and community affairs. This hinders women's participation in public functions. Considering the significance and two-fold impact on women and vulnerable populations in infrastructure development, the nation is getting late to prepare a policy that ensures women's participation in hydropower development.

(The author is professionally a chartered accountant (CA) and writes on sustainable development.)

Resilient South Korea Overcomes Challenges



Om Prakash Ghimire

The 'Global Knowledge Exchange and Development Centre' is a knowledge hub located in Seoul, the capital city of South Korea. Within this centre, Korea's development history is documented and demonstrated in a systematic manner.

During my recent visit to the Industrial Development Hall, one of the three halls of the Centre, a staff member pointed to a chart and said, "Despite the fact that Korea began its industrial development journey much later than the western world, it was able to achieve industrial progress within 50 years. For the western nations, it took nearly 200 years."

This information sparked a curiosity in me to further understand the nation's success in industrial development. Having gained independence in 1945 after 35 years of Japanese colonisation, the Korean Peninsula was divided into North Korea and South Korea. At the time of separation, South Korea lacked industries and factories. Also, it was going through a severe energy crisis, as about 80 per cent of energy sources were located in the North. The severe devastation caused by the Korean War (1950–July 1953) compelled the leadership to focus on addressing the basic needs of the citizens. Overcoming those challenges to realise the dream of a prosperous post-war Korea was necessary, but the leadership had to promptly tackle numerous other prevalent issues.

With the vision of transitioning the agriculture-based economy into an industrial one, thereby paving the way for the country's prosperity, Park Chung-hee, the immediate past president, who ascended to power through a military coup, articulated new goals and strategies for economic development. Aligned with his vision, in the 1960s, Korea formally declared its entry into the industrial era, leading to the establishment of the Korea Trade Promotion Institute and other agencies, along with the enactment of laws to boost exports. The same far-reaching thinking that guided Korea through its struggle to save the lives of its citizens has become the cornerstone of today's prosperous Korea.



Export-oriented policies

Until 1960, South Korea's economy heavily relied on agriculture, which constituted nearly 40 per cent of its industries. As the country was reeling from an acute shortage of energy, the then-Korean government prioritised production of goods requiring low energy consumption and initiated industrialization. Beginning with heavy machinery production, a long-term plan was devised. As part of that plan, the country adopted the policy of discouraging the assembly of imported parts from Japan. With the enactment of the Comprehensive Automobile Protection Act in 1962, the nation began manufacturing cars. In 1964, the Comprehensive Automobile Development Plan was endorsed, encouraging domestic car production. This plan is considered to be the starting point for Korean automobiles to exert influence on the global market today.



The government focused on energy savings for immediate consumption and creating employment opportunities for the production and export of light industrial goods. The effectiveness of that strategy is evident in the substantial increase in the export of light industrial products. In 1970, Korea's synthetic wig, a niche product, gained widespread popularity in the global market, resulting in a $94 million export value. This success highlights the prominence of Korea's third-largest export commodity at that time. Moreover, in the 1970s, Korea became the world's third-largest exporter of textiles. According to government statistics, textile exports in 1980 were 283 times higher than those in 1963.

In 1971, Korea's total exports comprised of 72 per cent of light industrial goods. However, signs of a decline in the export of such goods observed in the same decade led the government to shift its focus to the production of deep-seated items such as automobiles, steel, ships, and other heavy-duty products.

To promote long-term benefits for the private sector, the government introduced specific initiatives in 1967, including low-interest loans, land management, targeted manpower training programmes, and assistance in the pre-investment sector. The government implemented six laws to attract investments in major industries such as automobiles, shipbuilding, and steel production. In 1986, those laws were consolidated under the Industrial Development Act, replacing outdated regulations. This initiative streamlined Korea's industrial development and exports, contributing to a substantial average growth of 16 per cent between 1960 and 1980.

Implemented in 1973, the Automobile Promotion Plan discouraged the production of assembled cars, and in line with this plan, in 1976, the "Pony" car from the "Hyundai" company became the first car exported to Ecuador, opening up the global market for Korean automobiles. The Pony gained immense popularity, selling over 1.5 million cars annually in the American market within the first seven years of its launch. After successfully passing 288 tests, Korea began producing its own Alpha engine in 1991. By 1995, it had become the fifth-largest car-producing country in the world. Today, Korea has established itself as a dominant force in the global car market. In the 1990s, Korea achieved remarkable success in the production and export of ships as well. The industrial development has laid a strong foundation, contributing significantly to its economic growth.

New horizons from crisis

In the second half of the 1990s, the global economic recession observed in many countries, such as America, led to a fall in Korean trade and the economy. Bankrupted major companies and bank interest rates were hiked to 25 per cent. The pace of the buildup of foreign currency reserves slowed alarmingly. To address this situation, a move was undertaken in 1997 where the citizens gave an amount of gold that is equivalent to US$2. It was through the combined effort of citizen and government action that this momentum played a role in enabling Korea to transcend the crisis, setting it firmly on a path for further growth.

After the 1990s, Korea achieved notable success in the export business of automobiles, ships, steel, and mobile phones, as well as electrical appliances. Currently, Korea holds a significant 25 per cent share of the global smartphone market.

In 1953, the per capita income of Korea was only $67. At that time, Korea was one of the most underdeveloped nations in the world. According to government records in 2018, this figure has significantly risen to $31,350 per person, marking an increase of more than 440 times. Currently, Korea is not only included in the list of developed countries, but it also holds global economic and industrial leadership. Its development model has become a lesson for the world. Koreans assert that today's prosperity was born from a moment of crisis. They take pride in this achievement and consider it a source of national pride.

Even in times of crisis, the leadership that makes sincere efforts for the country's development and wins the trust of the people will receive widespread public support. The lesson to be learned from Korea is that a nation can be built through such a trustworthy partnership.

In 1950, Nepal had an income of $50 per person, but now it has risen to around $1,200. However, in 1961, South Korea had a per capita income of $94, and today it has surged to over $32,000. This might be one of the reasons behind this level of public trust in the government.

The example of South Korea illustrates that when the state works diligently towards development, it not only achieves progress by breaking barriers and crises but also gains increased trust from its citizens.

(Ghimire serves as a development journalist and social science researcher.)

Democracy And Civic Consciousness



Bibhav Pokhrel



Nepal, a country with about 30 million people, is a democratic and sovereign state. It has gone beyond the governance and constitutional monarchy stages. Despite that, we have suffered bitterly to move away from those systems at the expense of our blood through internal wars and chaos—everything inhumane. It is due to this kind of democracy that, after reaching such an age, we are able to get our own constitution, innumerable infrastructure projects besides civil policies, and so on. The main turning points in the political structure of Nepal are said to be two revolutions: 2046 BS and 2063/63 BS. After World War II, the practice of democracy became global, and Nepal too gained a democratic government for the first time about 73 years ago. Some people still believe that it is not correct to implement a democratic state such as Nepal. The main question regarding the above statement is the literacy rate. Though the literacy rate has risen to around 76 per cent recently, people's consciousness about democracy is still low. Countries like the US and UK claim that their normal people need not know everything regarding their political environment and government because they have evolved way too far to be respectful regarding systems and people.

But for a country like Nepal, it is still an issue to be concerned about. Though we got democracy 73 years ago for the first time, it has always been a concern to protect democracy rather than practice it. Because just after a decade of getting democracy, we faced an autocratic coup, which lasted almost 30 years. After that, we faced an internal chaotic war from 2052 to 2063 BS, which was a disaster. Then, after facing all this chaos, we got to practice free democracy just about 15 years ago. So, we can still say that it's a new practice for us. Instability has risen so far that we have not yet seen the government last for 5 years. People's concerns are still an issue. Basically, democracy gives us the power to get rid of those negative interferences in government through the medium of elections, which have been taking place almost regularly after 5 years. People's unconsciousness regarding selections has been a problem since we practiced democracy.

Liberty is the most precious gift that democracy offers to a country. The theoretical definition of democracy claims that there will be sustainable peace if there is democracy. But as everyone does, Nepal also has a system to run the administration of the country. If utilised properly, that system is the backbone of a country. But misuse of the system in a democracy leads a country into darkness. Internal diplomacy has been hollow regarding everything because the intellectual power of the people in power seems to be insufficient.

Geopolitically, Nepal is widely recognised as a vulnerable nation. We are encircled not just by two of the world's largest countries in terms of size but also by major players in global politics. Interference is common, occasionally exceeding acceptable limits. In practical terms, our country's diplomatic influence in international affairs is relatively modest. The two neighbouring giants and some distant major players pursue their own interests in our geography. In fact, here we see these two neighbouring countries almost competing with one another—either providing assistance to Nepal or undertaking major projects within our borders as a form of aid. Speculatively, the situation of Nepal's geopolitics would have been different if it were located somewhere else, thus providing us with information regarding our global standing and relations.

Civic consciousness is always important for the betterment of a country. There are a lot of issues that can be solved just by raising civic consciousness. Selecting a good government is the main one of them, because once we select the wrong ones for handling the system, there is not even a loophole for a minimum of 5 years to correct our mistake. Civic consciousness can also improve the standards, peace of the state, and personality of individuals.

One other important problem arising in Nepal is the involvement of foreign organisations and NGOs. Although not all of them, some seem to have a personal interest in our nation. By labelling themselves NGOs, they take advantage of a legal gap that allows them to operate without the blessing of their home countries and blindly follow their missions at any price. But it is hard for them to go unnoticed as society becomes more civilised.

Patriotism is closely related to civic consciousness. Today, many people dream of leaving Nepal. However, with the election of an efficient government that can govern the country well and protect our independence from meddling, there would be no necessity to go. This would bring peace, a promising future, and plenty of job opportunities to come here. Regrettably, owing to the lack of civic awareness, the discourse on leaving Nepal is too focused, as no one knows what actions ought to be taken.

It's important for people to understand how democracy works. Higher authorities should implement provisions to educate the public on civic consciousness through various channels, such as media and awareness programmes. Additionally, integrating these topics into the educational syllabus is the most effective way to underscore their importance. This approach ensures that these aspects become ingrained in individuals' subconscious minds, facilitating their implementation in practice.

(The writer is pursuing higher education.)

Impact Of Federalisation On Healthcare



Pallav Bhusal

Nepal has been on a journey of transformation in recent years, wherein the country shifted to a federal system that changed how governance and other services are done. This immense transition has transformed the entire system of health care, provided numerous benefits while posed various drawbacks. Pioneering research being carried out in the Bagmati, Karnali, and Lumbini regions, as well as Kathmandu, contributes much to understanding the complex dynamics between federalisation and healthcare.

The initial results from this research conducted by the Health Systems Research Initiative indicate a positive tendency towards developing Nepal's health system. In the last decades, the country has seen continual development, and this matches the positive trend since federalisation. But in the midst of this positivity, there are serious challenges that require consideration, which makes it an effective study for policymakers as well as stakeholders. One of the main issues highlighted in the research is confusion among different levels of government about their responsibilities. Governance is critical, and the lack of a clearly understood 'division of labour' can impair integrated healthcare services. The research team welcomes the idea of legislation being considered for better clarity and seeks greater transparency as well as efficiency in governance structures within the health system. Inadequate planning and the prevalence of temporary positions within the health workforce are identified as challenges.

Good healthcare depends on a trained and motivated workforce. The study righteously recommends reconsidering staff adjustment procedures, improving hiring transparency, and establishing a complete information system aimed at efficient workforce management. The procurement of medical products and technologies is very important for the effective implementation of health services. The study indicates that local procurement requires simplified control to prevent cases of over- and under-storage. The critical elements of legislation to clarify roles, strengthen data management, and involve experts for quality controls must be taken in order to secure a resilient medical procurement system.

The study brings attention to challenges in healthcare financing, with local governments struggling to fully utilise their budgets. Timely release of funds, along with training for elected representatives on health budgeting, can bridge these gaps and ensure a more efficient allocation of resources.

A glaring challenge lies in the fragmentation of health information systems. To enhance data-driven decision-making, the interoperability of software systems and the implementation of a nationwide electronic patient record system are essential. In service delivery, political influences must be replaced with evidence-informed decisions and community engagement for inclusive services.



The research team reaffirms the appeal of a participatory and collaborative approach among government levels, healthcare providers, and local communities. By adhering to the needs raised in this study and implementing policy suggestions, Nepal can facilitate a resilient, inclusive health system.

The next decade is pivotal for Nepal's health system, and the Health Sector Strategic Plan 2022–30 presents an opportune moment for decisive action. The research team urges policymakers to heed the findings of this study, considering it a compass guiding us towards a healthcare landscape that is both robust and equitable.

The project is a research collaboration between researchers from Nepal and the UK that received funding through the HSRI. Since 2020, a research team co-led by Professor Simon Rushton of the University of Sheffield, UK, as well as Professor Julie Balen from Canterbury Christ Church University, has begun to study federalism's impact on the Nepali health system.

Their collaborative efforts bring an international perspective to the study, enriching it with diverse insights and expertise. The exchange of knowledge between the academic communities in Nepal and the UK fosters a holistic understanding of the complex interplay between federalization and healthcare dynamics.

The current research investigates the heterogeneous effects of federalisation on health care. It analyses the complex interdependencies of governance structures, human resources development trends, procurement practices, budgetary allocation, and data management. In this regard, the insights that derive from their study are not simply observational but set in stone as a policy guideline and intervention.

The lack of clarity in the division of roles among different government levels emerges as a critical concern. The study recognises the necessity for an explicit 'division of labour' within the healthcare governance structure. It proposes legislative measures to define roles and responsibilities, fostering transparency and efficiency. By addressing this foundational issue, Nepal can establish a governance framework that ensures the seamless operation of healthcare services.

Inadequate planning and the prevalence of temporary positions within the health workforce represent additional challenges identified by the research. A resilient healthcare system hinges on a skilled and motivated workforce. The study advocates for revisiting staff adjustment processes, enhancing hiring transparency, and establishing a comprehensive data system for effective workforce management. These measures aim to address workforce-related bottlenecks and contribute to the overall improvement of healthcare services.

Efficient procurement of medical products and technologies emerges as a cornerstone of a successful health system. The study emphasises the need for streamlined oversight in local procurement to avoid issues of over- and under-stocking. Legislative measures are recommended to clarify roles, strengthen data management, and engage experts for quality checks in the medical procurement process. This strategic approach ensures the resilience of the medical procurement system, contributing to the overall effectiveness of healthcare delivery.

Addressing financial challenges is crucial for sustaining and enhancing healthcare services. The study sheds light on the struggle of local governments to fully utilise their healthcare budgets. Timely release of funds and targeted training for elected representatives on health budgeting are proposed as measures to bridge these gaps. These interventions aim to ensure a more efficient allocation of resources, thereby maximising the impact of healthcare budgets at the local level.

The fragmentation of health information systems poses a significant challenge to data-driven decision-making. The study advocates for the interoperability of software systems and the implementation of a nationwide electronic patient record system. These technological interventions are crucial for enhancing the accessibility and usability of health data. By replacing political influences with evidence-informed decisions and promoting community engagement in service delivery, Nepal can move towards a more inclusive and responsive healthcare system. As the study underscores the importance of collaboration, it calls for inclusive dialogue and joint efforts between government levels, healthcare professionals, and local communities.

(Bhusal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

> The study brings attention to challenges in healthcare financing, with local governments struggling to fully utilise their budgets.

FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

January 19th to 25th 2024 - D. N. Lohani

ARIES
You will enjoy pleasant meetings with interesting people. Regular gains will help consolidate your financial position. Hardship will guide you ahead on Tuesday. A health disorder is predicted for Thursday.

TAURUS
Fear and confusion can reside within oneself, but they won't cause much trouble. The expenditure level will rise on Friday. You may have to treat others at your own expense. The second half will contain a recovery phase. Travel is probable.

GEMINI
Income and expenditure will maintain balance. Travel is in store for you. Business-related travel can take place. Study will take a progressive course. The expenditure level will rise tomorrow.

CANCER
Foreign travel is probable. Work will face obstacles. You may even gain a new job. Opponents can attempt to influence business, but their attempts will fail. Job-related problems can arise.

LEO
The work will be completed after causing extra expenses. Philanthropic ventures will advance. Children's education-related expenses will rise. The expenditure level will rise on Thursday.

VIRGO
You may hear unpleasant news during the start. Circumstances will improve tomorrow. With some effort, business will prosper. Love life can face obstacles. One or more concerns will keep bothering you.

LIBRA
Social prestige won't rise. You will find it difficult to complete tasks without a friend's support. With some effort, writing skills will be enhanced. The love life will take a progressive course.

SCORPIO
Work will be completed after hardship. You will find it difficult to control expenses. Handle valuable goods cautiously on Tuesday. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. You will enjoy impressive gains on Thursday. The job will yield lower satisfaction.

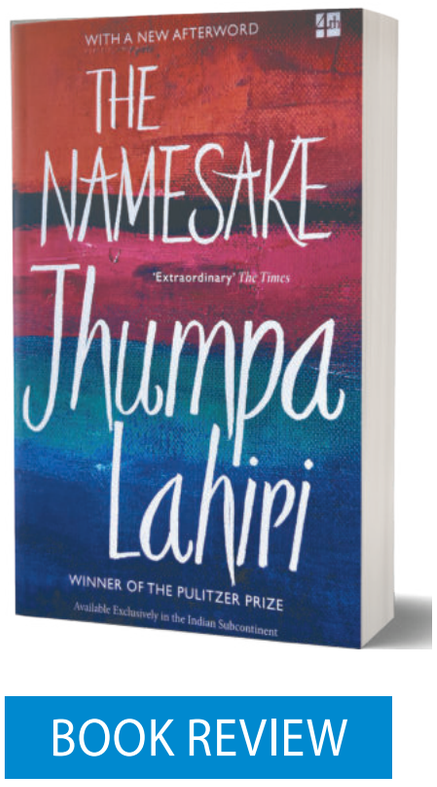
SAGITTARIUS
Fear can reside within the self. Relocation can take place. Real estate transactions can occur, though I don't see much gain. With some effort, study will advance. Employees will feel better.

CAPRICORN
Uncertainty can arise. Travel is in store for you. You may have to handle a new assignment, but you will remain less pleased. Business-related travel can occur. Distant friends will cooperate.

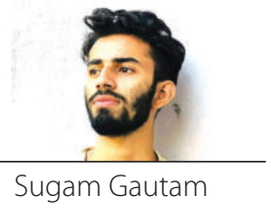
AQUARIUS
You will retain partial progress in your obligation. Study will take a progressive course. You may even go abroad to study. Jobs can face instability. A health disorder is predicted for tomorrow.

PISCES
A health disorder is predicted for the mid-portion. Start and end are better. You will retain progress in the academic sector. Health conditions will gradually improve. The expenditure level will rise. Worshipping Devi can provide support.

Masterful Storytelling With Flawless Writing



BOOK REVIEW



Sugam Gautam

Book name: The Namesake , Written by: Jhumpa Lahiri, Genre: Fiction, Language: English

I had already read all of Jhumpa Lahiri's works before finally delving into her debut novel, "The Namesake." Like every other time, I'm left amazed by her magical craft and her ability to make trivial things appear larger and more important. Jhumpa Lahiri never plots ambitious narratives; all she does is grasp the quotidian and drive the narrative forward seamlessly with her flawless writing. "The Namesake" falls under the same category.

One day, as Ashoke Ganguli travels by train to his grandparents' house, he encounters a man who has travelled to different parts of the world. This man suggests to Ashoke that leaving his land provides an opportunity to see the world from a new perspective. Before this encounter, Ashoke had never considered going to other countries, spending the majority of his years in a foreign land where, in the initial days, he would have to struggle for his identity. Unfortunately, that night, the train derailed, resulting in the deaths of hundreds, including the man who suggested Ashoke go beyond the borders of his country. Ashoke is fortunate enough to survive the disaster, but the years that follow are no less perilous as he stays bedridden, unable to walk or travel. Strangely, a book written by his favorite author, Nikolai Gogol, also survives the chaos. After recovery, Ashoke marries, and then, as the man on the train had suggested, he departs for the US, trying to obliterate the train accident from his mind. However, the images of that horrible night loom in his mind every now and then. When Ashoke and Ashima become parents, they wait for Ashima's grandmother's letter bearing the name of the newborn. For some reason, the letter never reaches the mailbox of Ashoke's apartment in the US. The newborn is named, temporarily, after Ashoke's favourite author, Nikolai Gogol. They assume that the grandmother's letter will find them someday, and then they can replace the temporary name with the one on the letter. The temporary name, only used by family members, becomes the official name of the boy as they fail to find the letter. The grandmother, not in good health, eventually dies, disrupting the pattern of her keeping the names of the grandchildren.

The novel showcases the difference between the cultures of India and the US through characters like Ashoke, Ashima, and Gogol. Gogol's younger sister, Sonia, is not emphasised, as the author chooses to drive the narrative through the experiences and understandings of Gogol. Gogol is uncomfortable with his name; his classmates in the US, he thinks, have popular and stylish names. When he is occasionally taken to India for Durga Puja, he doesn't connect to the places and relatives in India. He feels like one of those Americans, puzzled by the enormous set of formalities. In the US, his home, on special occasions, is always crowded by his parents' Bengali friends. The closest he ever comes to India is through these people: his father's anticipation for a party to be held in their house and his mother's relentless efforts in the kitchen for days on end. In gatherings, the other children, like him, are always bored and watching TV, leaving the adults among themselves, making them feel more like Indians. A professor at a US-based university, Ashoke, figures out that his son hasn't inherited Indian culture. Ashoke and Ashima never complain to Gogol for not doing certain things like Indian people generally do. When Gogol grows up, he even changes his name to Nikhil. Yet he remains Gogol to his parents and the people he knows as his parents' friends. At the peak of his youth, he makes an American girl his girlfriend. Though his parents show no signs of disapproval, he knows that they don't want him to marry her.

Ashima, a quiet woman, hates having her family members away from the house for too long. Ashoke has been on an educational trip for a long time; Gogol is with his girlfriend's family on vacation; and Sonia is in a different city for studies. And then, suddenly, one day, she is informed about the untimely demise of her husband. The death of his father transforms Gogol into a thoughtful figure; thereafter, he starts realising the silent love of his father. Some years later, he marries a Bengali girl who has been living in the US. Though the relationship shows some promise, the girl cheats him, and once again, he becomes a single man. By the time he turns thirty-two, he has seen it all: his parents' struggle in the US, the stark distinction between the cultures, the love of his parents, and the most heartbreaking—the death of his father.

The novel evokes a sense of transformation one goes through in life, showing why a person can't forget his roots. Ashima, a widow, sells the US house and plans on dividing her time between India and her children's apartment. Though the love shared between Ashima and Ashoke is not expressive, readers feel a deep connection that binds them together in a foreign pasture. The novel is well-paced, and by the time you finish reading the book, you are transported to a different world, a world of Gogol and his family. It's as if Jhumpa Lahiri stands on the aisle between two cultures, gazing with compassion to discern the tiniest nuances. You just can't forget the characters built by Jhumpa Lahiri. Her writing is a testament to what people describe as meticulous work. The fine details she sketches will keep you engrossed, not wanting to let go of the book. With her masterful storytelling and well-developed characters, Jhumpa Lahiri has certainly given a masterpiece to the literary world—one that will be cherished for ages.

(The author is a writer from Pokhara.)

Winter Guide For People With Diabetes



Dr. Shashi Sharma

> Numerous indoor activities offer opportunities for staying active without leaving your home. These include practicing yoga, climbing stairs, dancing, and even household chores like cleaning the room.

Navigating the winter months with diabetes presents a unique set of challenges as the world transforms into a landscape of snow and cold. Individuals grappling with diabetes must confront various complexities, from managing blood sugar levels in the face of temperature drops to paying extra attention to foot care and safeguarding mental well-being.

The winter season often tempts people to be less active due to the chilly weather and the allure of confronting, indulgent foods. Despite the reluctance to leave the warmth of a cozy bed during the winter, maintaining a sedentary lifestyle can be particularly detrimental, especially for individuals with diabetes. Interestingly, our metabolism tends to function well in the winter, presenting an ideal opportunity to embark on weight-loss efforts during this season. This comprehensive guide aims to empower those with diabetes by providing insights and practical tips to successfully navigate the intricacies of the winter season.

Understanding the impact of winter on diabetes is the foundational step in crafting an effective strategy. The drop in temperature can influence blood circulation, potentially increasing the risk of heart-related complications. Awareness of these challenges lays the groundwork for a tailored approach to managing diabetes during the winter months.

Creating a warm and comfortable environment is crucial for individuals with diabetes, as the cold can exacerbate complications. Maintaining a warm living space by setting the thermostat to at least 18 degrees Celsius in frequently used rooms is essential. Exploring financial assistance options or grants to enhance energy efficiency can further contribute to creating a comfortable and diabetes-friendly environment.

Monitoring blood sugar levels becomes even more critical during the winter. The cold weather can impact blood sugar levels, necessitating more frequent testing. Overcoming challenges such as cold hands during finger-prick testing can be addressed by using hand warmers or holding a warm cup of tea before testing.



Caring for feet in cold conditions is imperative, as winter demands heightened attention to foot care. Despite the need for layering, daily foot checks remain essential. Individuals with diabetes should exercise caution when using heating devices to prevent burns, especially for those with neuropathy.

Ensuring medication and equipment safety is paramount in the winter. The extreme cold can adversely affect insulin and diabetes testing equipment. Storing insulin at room temperature and keeping testing equipment, as well as insulin pump handsets, in insulated pockets when venturing outdoors becomes a crucial practice.

Prioritising vaccinations is integral to safeguarding overall health during the winter months. Individuals with diabetes are vulnerable to winter viruses, highlighting the critical importance of staying up to date on flu jabs and COVID boosters.

Mental health and emotional well-being are often overlooked aspects of diabetes management during the winter. The gloom of winter can cast a shadow on mental health, potentially impacting blood sugar levels. Seeking support from healthcare professionals, family, or engaging with online forums is crucial to effectively managing stress and emotional well-being during the colder months.

Addressing the financial aspect of diabetes management is another key consideration. The cost of living, including energy bills, can pose a formidable challenge for those managing diabetes. Advocating for guaranteed protection against energy disconnection and seeking resources to alleviate financial burdens associated with diabetes care are essential steps towards a more secure winter.

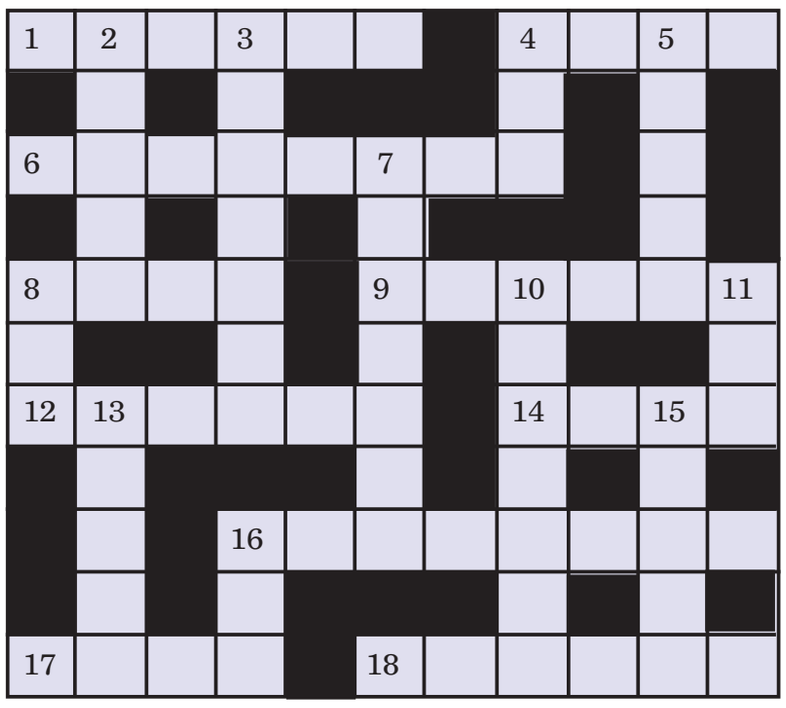
Nutrition plays a pivotal role in blood sugar control, and maintaining a well-balanced diet is paramount. Individuals should be mindful of their alcohol intake, understanding that it can lead to heat loss and dilated blood vessels, contrary to the common perception of providing warmth.

Staying active indoors is crucial for diabetes management, even during the colder months. Engaging in a brief daily exercise routine for a minimum of 30 minutes can enhance your insulin sensitivity, aid in more effective regulation of sugar levels, promote warmth, and potentially boost your mood. Monitoring blood sugar levels, especially for those using insulin, is crucial. During the winter, reduced physical activity may result in inadequate glycemic control, making it essential not to neglect walking even in inclement weather. Numerous indoor activities offer opportunities for staying active without leaving your home. These include practicing yoga, climbing stairs, dancing, and even household chores like cleaning the room.

In conclusion, thriving with diabetes during the winter necessitates a holistic approach that encompasses physical, emotional, and financial well-being. Armed with knowledge and proactive measures, individuals with diabetes can not only overcome the challenges posed by winter but also ensure a season of good health and well-being. Regular communication with health care teams and a strong support network are essential components of a successful winter diabetes management strategy, ensuring a journey through winter that is both comfortable and healthy.

(The author is a consultant physician and Assistant Professor of Internal Medicine at Purbanchal University Teaching Hospital, Gothgaun, Morang.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1774



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
January 24, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across

1. Abuser
4. Very eager and enthusiastic
6. A serious disagreement
8. Have you read that one?
9. Explosives used as detonator
12. Make extremely annoyed
14. Talk wildly
16. Complying with a request
17. A harmful plan made in secret
18. They collect, dispose ashes

Down

2. Remote-controlled flying device
3. Soaked tea in water
4. Law
5. Indicate the truth
7. Of extreme force
8. Non-Aligned Movement
10. Damage reputation
11. Intentionally a false statement
13. Declare invalid
15. Place where a meeting is held
16. Make a choice from

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1773

ACROSS: 1. CANCER 4. CAST 6. FINANCES 8. SNAG 9. ENABLE 12. CRISIS 14. GOAD 16. LEAFLETS 17. STAB 18. ACCORD

DOWN: 2. ASIAN 3. CHARGES 4.COS 5. SPILL 7.CHELSEA 8. SEC 10. ANGELIC 11. END 13. ROBOT 15. ACTOR 16. LOB

LUCKY WINNER

Rekha Rajopadhyaya
Krishna Chandra Gautam
Sunil Sharma Bhattarai

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Bal Krishna Shrestha, Damodar Lohani, Radheshyam Shrestha, Archana Devi Shrestha, Surya Shakya, Feroj Rajopadhyaya, Mana Raja Juju,

CREATIVE CORNER



Nirjala Batala, Grade: IV, Pioneers Scholars Academy, Kailali



Ojaswee Aryal, Grade V, Gyan Niketan Secondary School

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-406

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 483 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 45 to 93 between. The number should not be used twice.

74		92		54		72
82		51		62		73
90		52		70		81
49		60		78		89
57		68		86		48
65		76		87		56
66		84		46		64

71	80	89	42	51	60	69
79	88	48	50	59	68	70
87	47	49	58	67	76	78
46	55	57	66	75	77	86
54	56	65	74	83	85	45
62	64	73	82	84	44	53
63	72	81	90	43	52	61

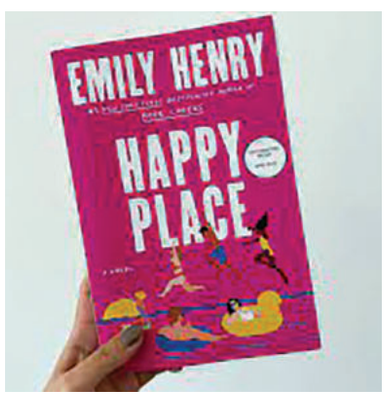
TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-405

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel

Friendship Resonance



Kusum Gautam



"Happy Place" is a romantic comedy novel by Emily Henry about two friends, Harriet and Wyn, who pretend to be in a relationship for one week. They have maintained an ideal relationship since their encounter in college—they complement each other harmoniously, like essential seasonings, a delightful combination of sweetness and warmth, or a classic pairing of seafood and bread. However, for the time being, they have chosen not to disclose the reasons behind their decision. Their relationship ended five months ago. Furthermore, they have not yet disclosed this information to their closest companions.

Furthermore, they have not yet disclosed this information to their closest companions. Thus, they find themselves sharing the most spacious bedroom in the Maine cottage, which has been used as their group's annual vacation for the past ten years. During their yearly vacation, they escape from their everyday routines and engage themselves in a week of luxuries, enjoying a large amount of cheese, wine, and seafood. They love the coastal atmosphere alongside those who truly understand them. This year, Harriet and Wyn are intentionally hiding their strong desire for each other. Given that the cottage is now on the market for sale, this upcoming week will be the final opportunity for all of them to spend time together in this location. They are unwilling to cause emotional distress to their friends, so they will act according to expectations. Harriet will represent the determined surgical resident who avoids creating conflicts, whereas Wyn will represent the relaxed and charismatic individual who conceals any vulnerabilities. The strategy appears flawless when observed from a significant distance through a pair of sunglasses streaked with sunscreen. After experiencing years of romantic affection, how challenging could it really be to fake those emotions for just seven days?

Happy Place is not an exception, and I believe it surpasses Book Lovers in quality (although People We Meet on Vacation remains my favorite). The narrative delves beyond an ordinary tale of failed romance, exploring the lengths individuals go to in order to appease others and the evolution of friendships over time. It is an enjoyable and emotionally encouraging book, especially when it takes place during the summer and you are reading it in the winter. This book celebrates friendship, false dating, and second chances. If you're in your 30s with friends you've known since college or high school, you know the beautiful highs and tragic lows of true friendship. Working hard can be difficult, and life can make it easy to let go. Harriet is unprepared to breakdown with her two best friends, hotshot lawyer Sabrina and down-to-earth farmer Cleo, but it's inevitable. In those moments, individuals you assumed would stay by your side, like additional limbs, start to leave. You find that your long-lasting, ideal fit is now ragged. Your edges look off. Stuff hurts. Honestly, it aches. Henry masterfully writes about the attractive beach village, offsetting Harriet's drama, including her desire to maintain appearances with her ex, Wyn.

So, this is officially my best book by Emily Henry, and it deserves all the love and hope! Emily's writing, particularly her conversations, is truly exceptional. These experiences are guaranteed to immerse you in the core of the narrative, evoking powerful emotions that leave you helpless to take any action. The book is set at a Maine cottage where the people in the story are able to fully immerse themselves in the lobster feast, which proves to be highly suitable for the narrative. The book "Happy Place" is primarily focused on its characters, and Emily deserves praise for her ability to create and grow characters that openly and brutally express their smallest emotions, flaws, and anxieties.

The painful stretching, popping, and breaking of growth as you stumble from college graduation into adulthood, absorbing and transforming lessons. The writing is witty and charming. Emily Henry has a gift for creating dialogue that is both funny and heartwarming. Overall, Happy Place is a delightful novel that will leave you feeling happy and hopeful. It's a perfect book for fans of romantic comedies or anyone who is looking for a feel-good story.

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